

dào dé jīng
道 德 經
way virtue classic

Dao De Jing

Preface

Like the *Dao De Jing* itself, what this version offers is the opportunity to let the book truly be yours. Yes, the *Dao De Jing* seems cryptic in this presentation—but it is similarly cryptic for the Chinese scholar. This non-translated version allows you to experience the philosophy fully, as close as it was meant to be perceived.

Above most lines, you will find a short insightful question that serves as a gentle guide or hint to aid your exploration. The calques have been prepared to match the most literal sense of each word that still ties into the context, with great care to select the appropriate semantic field closest to the classical Chinese. The modern pinyin is also provided in case you want to search up a word, but note that the classical Chinese of Laozi's era was probably spoken quite differently.

We encourage you: don't rush to try and understand or translate. Sit with a few lines first, contemplate the meaning of the words and their potential interpretations. Frustration is normal. We are confident that this way of presenting is the best way to truly grok Daoism—after all, the *Dao De Jing* was written to explore language itself too.

Introduction

Classical Chinese (文言文) served as the literary language of China for over two millennia, remaining relatively unchanged while spoken language evolved dramatically. The text you're about to encounter is presented with word-by-word calques—literal translations that preserve the original structure while providing access to the meaning. This approach offers a window into both the content and the distinctive patterns of classical Chinese thought.

Reading classical Chinese requires a different mindset than approaching modern languages. The grammar is exceptionally economical, with single characters often carrying multiple potential functions. Context, rather than explicit markers, determines meaning. What might seem frustratingly ambiguous to the modern reader was considered elegant and profound by classical scholars—indeed, this ambiguity is often central to the philosophical insights being conveyed.

Key Features of Classical Chinese

1. Extreme Concision

Classical Chinese prized brevity. A text like the *Dao De Jing* exemplifies this quality, with profound concepts expressed in just a few characters. What might require a

paragraph in English often appears as a simple four-character phrase in classical Chinese. This concision isn't merely stylistic—it reflects a philosophical belief that excessive words obscure truth rather than reveal it.

2. Fluid Part of Speech

Unlike English, where words typically function as specific parts of speech, classical Chinese words shift freely between roles. A character might serve as a noun in one context, a verb in another, and an adjective in a third. This fluidity allows for remarkable linguistic economy but requires readers to remain attentive to context.

3. Implied Subjects and Objects

Classical Chinese frequently omits subjects and objects when they can be inferred from context. Modern readers often find themselves asking *who* or *what* when translating these passages. The answer typically lies in the broader context of the discussion.

Essential Grammatical Words

The following function words form the backbone of classical Chinese grammar. Understanding them will significantly enhance your reading experience:

The following table presents the essential grammatical particles that will be explained in detail:

Character	Pinyin	Primary Functions
之	zhī	Possessive marker, object pronoun, nominalizer
者	zhě	Nominalizer, topic marker
也	yě	Assertion marker, copula
其	qí	Possessive pronoun, hypothetical marker
而	ér	Conjunction, adverbial marker

以	<i>yǐ</i>	Instrumental marker, causative marker
於	<i>yú</i>	Locative marker, comparative marker
故	<i>gù</i>	Logical connector, cause marker
兮	<i>xī</i>	Rhythmic pause marker

Each particle will be illustrated with examples showing its usage in context, along with English equivalents to help clarify their functions in classical Chinese texts.

之 (*zhī*)

Perhaps the most versatile particle in classical Chinese, 之:

tiān
天
heaven

zhī
之
's

dào
道
way

Functions as a possessive marker (similar to ‘s or of)

The way of Heaven

jiàn
見
see

zhī
之
it

Serves as an object pronoun (*it, him, her, them*)

See it/him/her/them

shàn
善
good

zhī
之
of

wéi
為
being

shàn
善
good

Creating nominalization (turning verbs or phrases into nouns)

The goodness of goodness

wǎng
往
go

zhī
之
toward

Acts as a directional particle indicating movement

Go toward it

When you encounter 之, ask yourself if it's connecting a possessor and possessed, replacing an object, creating a noun phrase, or indicating direction.

其 (qí)

This character typically:

qí mù
其 母
its/their mother

Works as a possessive pronoun (“his,” “her,” “its,” “their”)

its mother

qí rén
其 人
that person

Functions as a demonstrative (“that”)

that person

qí sǐ hū
其 死 乎
it die ?

Introduces a projected or hypothetical situation

Will it die?

The context often determines whether 其 indicates possession or serves a demonstrative function.

也 (yě)

This final particle:

yě dào
也 道
indeed way

Marks declarative statements (similar to a period or “indeed”).

It is the Way.

yě shàn
也 善
indeed good

Creates emphasis or assertion.

It is indeed good.

者 (zhě)

This nominalizer:

wéi xué zhě
為 學 者
do study one who

Transforms verbs or phrases into nouns (like “-er” or “one who”).

one who studies

shàn zhě
善 者
good that which is

Creates abstract concepts.

goodness

Marks the topic in a topic-comment structure.

dào zhě wàn wù zhī ào
道 者 萬 物 之 奧
way topic marker ten thousand things of mystery

The Way is the mystery of all things.

而 (ér)

This conjunctive particle:

wéi ér bù shì
為 而 不 恃
act and yet not rely on

Connects related clauses (*and, but, yet, while*).

act and yet do not rely on

shēng ér bù yǒu
生 而 不 有
give life and then not possess

Indicates sequence (*and then*).

give life and then do not possess

dà zhí ruò qū
大 直 若 屈
great straightness seems bent

Shows contrast (*but, yet*).

great straightness seems bent

以 (yǐ)

This versatile word marks instrumental use (*by, with, using*):

yǐ shēn guān qí miào
以 身 觀 其 妙
using oneself observe it wonder

Shows purpose (*in order to*).

in order to observe its wonder

yǐ qí wú sī
以 其 無 私
because it without self

Indicates causation (*because*).

because of its selflessness

於 (yú)

This preposition indicates

chǔ yú shàng
處 於 上
dwell at high

Location (*at, in*):

dwells in the high place

dà yú qí xì
大 於 其 細
greater than its small parts

Comparison (*than*):

greater than its small parts

guī yú wú wù
歸 於 無 物
returns to no thing

Direction (*to, toward*):

returns to nothingness

故 (*gù*)

This logical connector:

gù néng cháng shēng
故 能 長 生
therefore can long live

Shows causation (*therefore, thus*):

therefore can live long

gù qù bǐ qǔ cǐ
故 去 彼 取 此
therefore reject that take this

Introduces explanation (*because, for*):

therefore reject that and take this

兮 (*xī*)

This particle:

zhàn xī
湛 兮
profound exclamation

Marks rhythmic pause in poetic texts, like *ah*!

profound, ah!

Reading Strategies

1. Look for Parallelism

Classical Chinese texts, especially philosophical works, frequently use parallel structures where successive phrases follow identical grammatical patterns. Identifying these patterns helps clarify meaning:

tiān	cháng	dì	jiǔ
天	長	地	久
heaven	long	earth	enduring

Heaven is long, Earth is enduring

tiān	dì	suǒ	yǐ	néng	cháng	qiè	jiǔ	zhě
天	地	所	以	能	長	且	久	者
heaven	earth	that which	by means of	can	long	and	enduring	nominalizer

The reason heaven and earth can be long and enduring

yǐ	qí	bù	zì	shēng
以	其	不	自	生
because	they	not	self	live

is because they do not live for themselves

Here, the parallelism reveals the philosophical point through structural repetition.

2. Recognize Common Patterns

Certain grammatical patterns appear frequently:

- X 之 Y: Typically *Y of X* or *X's Y*
- X 者 Y 也: *X is Y* or *As for X, it is Y*
- 非 X 也: *It is not X*
- X 而 Y: *X and Y* or *X but Y*
- 以 X 為 Y: *Take X as Y* or *Use X for Y*

3. Pay Attention to Pronouns

Classical Chinese pronouns are context-dependent. The same character might refer to different entities within a single passage. When you encounter pronouns like 其, 之, or 吾, ask yourself what they're referencing.

4. Understand Implicit Logic

Classical Chinese often omits logical connectors that would be required in English. Statements may appear side by side without explicit indication of their relationship. Look for implied causation, contrast, or sequence.

5. Embrace Ambiguity

Many classical texts, particularly Daoist works like the one you're about to read, intentionally employ ambiguity as a philosophical tool.

Multiple valid interpretations may exist simultaneously—this isn't a failure of the text but often its intended effect.

About This Edition's Calques

The calque format used in this edition presents each Chinese character with its pronunciation and a direct English equivalent, preserving the original structure while making the text accessible:

These calques represent an intermediate step between the original text and a fluid translation. They reveal the grammatical structure while the commentaries provide context and interpretive guidance.

As you read, allow the original pattern of thought to emerge through this format. The seemingly strange word order and unexpected connections are not deficiencies but rather windows into a different way of conceptualizing reality. By meeting the text on its own terms, you'll discover not just what it says, but how classical Chinese thought itself was structured.

This approach invites you to participate in the interpretive process rather than receiving a finished translation. In this way, you'll experience something closer to how these texts have been read throughout Chinese history—as living documents that reveal different facets of meaning with each encounter.

A Final Invitation

As you prepare to engage with the *Dao De Jing*, remember this timeless wisdom from the text:

qiān	lǐ	zhī	xíng	shǐ	yú	zú	xià
千	里	之	行	始	於	足	下
thousand	li	's	journey	begins	with	foot	beneath

A reminder that even the greatest endeavors start with a single step.

A journey of a thousand li begins beneath one's feet!

Don't be intimidated by the vastness of this ancient text. Like any journey, your exploration begins with a single step. Take it one character at a time, and before you know it, you'll have traveled far in your understanding.

Enjoy the journey!

Chapter 1

The Way that can be spoken is not the eternal Way.

dào	kě	dào	fēi	cháng	dào
道	可	道	非	常	道
way	can	speak	not	constant	way

The name that can be named is not the eternal name.

míng	kě	míng	fēi	cháng	míng
名	可	名	非	常	名
name	can	named	not	constant	name

The nameless is the origin of heaven and earth.

wú	míng	tiān	dì	zhī	shǐ
無	名	天	地	之	始
without	name	heaven	earth	of	beginning

The named is the mother of ten thousand things.

yǒu	míng	wàn	wù	zhī	mǔ
有	名	萬	物	之	母
having	name	ten-thousand	things	of	mother

Therefore, constantly without desire, one observes its mysteries.

gù	cháng	wú	yù	yǐ	guān	qí	miào
故	常	無	欲	以	觀	其	妙
therefore	constant	without	desire	by-means-of	observe	its	mystery

Constantly with desire, one observes its manifestations.

cháng	yǒu	yù	yǐ	guān	qí	jiào
常	有	欲	以	觀	其	徼
constant	having	desire	by-means-of	observe	its	boundary

These two emerge together but have different names.

cǐ	liǎng	zhě	tóng	chū	ér	yì	míng
此	兩	者	同	出	而	異	名
these	two	ones	same	emerge	yet	different	name

Together they are called mystery.

tóng	wèi	zhī	xuán
同	謂	之	玄
together	called	it	dark-mystery

Mystery of mysteries.

xuán	zhī	yòu	xuán
玄	之	又	玄
dark-mystery	of	further	dark-mystery

The gateway to all mysteries.

zhòng	miào	zhī	mén
眾	妙	之	門
many	mysteries	of	gateway

Chapter 2

All under heaven know beauty as beauty, thus ugliness exists.

tiān xià	jiē	zhī	měi	zhī	wéi	měi	sī	è
天下	皆	知	美	之	為	美	斯	惡
under-heaven	all	know	beauty	of	become	beauty	then	ugly

yǐ

已

already

All know good as good, thus not-good exists.

jiē	zhī	shàn	zhī	wéi	shàn	sī	bù	shàn
皆	知	善	之	為	善	斯	不	善
all	know	good	of	become	good	then	not	good

yǐ

已

already

Therefore being and non-being give birth to each other.

gù	yǒu	wú	xiāng	shēng
故	有	無	相	生
therefore	have	not-have	mutually	generate

Difficult and easy complement each other.

nán	yì	xiāng	chéng
難	易	相	成
difficult	easy	mutually	complete

Long and short contrast each other.

cháng	duǎn	xiāng	jiào
長	短	相	較
long	short	mutually	compare

High and low lean upon each other.

gāo	xià	xiāng	qīng
高	下	相	傾
high	low	mutually	incline

Voice and sound harmonize with each other.

yīn	shēng	xiāng	hé
音	聲	相	和
tone	sound	mutually	harmonize

Front and back follow each other.

qián	hòu	xiāng	suí
前	後	相	隨
front	back	mutually	follow

Therefore the sage

shì	yǐ	shèng	rén
是	以	聖	人
this	by-means-of	sage	person

Dwells in affairs of non-action

chǔ	wú wéi	zhī	shì
處	無為	之	事
dwelt	non-action	of	affairs

Practices teaching without words

xíng	bù	yán	zhī	jiào
行	不	言	之	教
practice	not	speak	of	teaching

Ten thousand things arise but he does not initiate

wàn	wù	zuò	—	ér	bù	shǐ
萬	物	作	—	而	不	始
ten-thousand	things	arise		yet	not	initiate

Creates but does not possess

shēng	ér	bù	yǒu
生	而	不	有
create	yet	not	have

Acts but does not rely

wéi	ér	bù	shì
為	而	不	恃
act	yet	not	rely

Accomplishes but does not dwell

gōng	chéng	ér	fú	jū
功	成	而	弗	居
merit	complete	yet	not	dwell

Only because he does not dwell

fú	wéi	fú	jū
夫	唯	弗	居
indeed	only	not	dwell

Therefore it does not leave

shì	yǐ	bù	qù
是	以	不	去
this	by-means-of	not	leave

Chapter 3

Do not exalt the talented

bù	shàng	xián
不	尚	賢
not	exalt	worthy

So the people will not compete

shǐ	mín	bù	zhēng
使	民	不	爭
cause	people	not	compete

Do not value rare treasures

bù	guì	nán	dé	zhī	huò
不	貴	難	得	之	貨
not	value	difficult	obtain	of	goods

So the people will not steal

shǐ	mín	bù	wéi	dào
使	民	不	為	盜
cause	people	not	become	thief

Do not display what is desirable

bù	jiàn	kě	yù
不	見	可	欲
not	show	can	desire

So the people's hearts will not be disturbed

shǐ	mín	xīn	bù	luàn
使	民	心	不	亂
cause	people	heart	not	chaos

Therefore the sage governs by

shì	yǐ	shèng	rén	zhī	zhì
是	以	聖	人	之	治
this	by-means-of	sage	person	of	govern

Emptying their hearts and filling their bellies

xū	qí	xīn	shí	qí	fù
虛	其	心	實	其	腹
empty	their	heart	fill	their	belly

Weakening their ambitions and strengthening their bones

ruò	qí	zhì	qiáng	qí	gǔ
弱	其	志	強	其	骨
weaken	their	will	strengthen	their	bone

Always keeping the people without knowledge and without desire

cháng	shǐ	mín	wú	zhī	wú	yù
常	使	民	無	知	無	欲
always	cause	people	without	knowledge	without	desire

Causing the clever ones to not dare to act

shǐ	fū	zhì	zhě	bù	gǎn	wéi	
使	夫	智	者	不	敢	為	—
cause	those	wise	ones	not	dare	act	

Practice non-action and everything will be in order

wéi	wú	wéi	zé	wú	bù	zhì	yǐ
為	無	為	則	無	不	治	矣
do	nothing	do	then	nothing	not	order	indeed

Chapter 4

The Dao is empty, yet its use is inexhaustible.

dào	zhōng	ér	yòng	zhī	yǒu	bù	yíng
道	盅	而	用	之	有	不	盈
way	empty	yet	use	it	exist	not	full

Deep and profound, it seems to be the ancestor of all things.

yuān	xī	sì	wàn	wù	zhī	zōng
淵	兮	似	萬	物	之	宗
deep	!	like	ten-thousand	things	of	ancestor

Blunt the sharpness.

cuò	qí	ruì
挫	其	銳
blunt	its	sharp

Untangle the knots.

jiě	qí	fēn
解	其	紛
untie	its	tangled

Soften the glare.

hé	qí	guāng
和	其	光
harmonize	its	light

Merge with the dust.

tóng	qí	chén
同	其	塵
unite	its	dust

Deep and clear, it seems to exist.

zhàn	xī	sì	huò	cún
湛	兮	似	或	存
deep-clear	!	like	perhaps	exist

I do not know whose child it is.

wú	bù	zhī	shuí	zhī	zǐ
吾	不	知	誰	之	子
I	not	know	who	of	child

It appears to precede the Emperor.

xiàng	dì	zhī	xiān
象	帝	之	先
appear	emperor	of	before

Chapter 5

Heaven and Earth are not humane

tiān	dì	bù	rén
天	地	不	仁
heaven	earth	not	benevolent

They treat the ten thousand things as straw dogs

yì	wàn	wù	wéi	chú gǒu
以	萬	物	為	芻狗
by-means-of	ten-thousand	things	make	straw-dogs

The sage is not humane

shèng	rén	bù	rén
聖	人	不	仁
sage	person	not	benevolent

And treats the hundred families as straw dogs

yì	bǎi	xìng	wéi	chú gǒu
以	百	姓	為	芻狗
by-means-of	hundred	surnames	make	straw-dogs

Between Heaven and Earth

tiān	dì	zhī	jiān
天	地	之	間
heaven	earth	of	between

Is it not like a bellows?

qí	yóu	tuó yuè	hū
其	猶	橐籥	乎
its	like	bellows	question

Empty yet inexhaustible

xū	ér	bù	qū
虛	而	不	屈
empty	yet	not	bend

Moving, it yields more and more

dòng	ér	yù	chū
動	而	愈	出
move	yet	more	produce

Much talk leads to swift exhaustion

duō	yán	shuò	qióng
多	言	數	窮
much	speech	count	exhaust

Better to maintain the center

bù	rú	shǒu	zhōng
不	如	守	中
not	like	keep	center

Chapter 6

The valley spirit never dies.

gǔ	shén	bù	sǐ
谷	神	不	死
valley	spirit	not	die

This is called the mysterious feminine.

shì	wèi	xuán	pīn
是	謂	玄	牝
this	called	mysterious	female

The gateway of the mysterious feminine,

xuán	pīn	zhī	mén
玄	牝	之	門
mysterious	female	of	gateway

Is called the root of heaven and earth.

shì	wèi	tiān	dì	zhī	gēn
是	謂	天	地	之	根
this	called	heaven	earth	of	root

Continuous, seeming to persist,

mián	mián	ruò	cún
綿	綿	若	存
continuous	continuous	like	exist

Its use never exhausted.

yòng	zhī	bù	qín
用	之	不	勤
use	it	not	toil

Chapter 7

Heaven is lasting and Earth enduring.

tiān	cháng	dì	jiǔ
天	長	地	久
heaven	lasting	earth	enduring

The reason Heaven and Earth can be lasting and enduring is

tiān	dì	suǒyī	néng	cháng	qiě	jiǔ	zhě
天	地	所以	能	長	且	久	者
heaven	earth	reason-why	can	lasting	and	enduring	one-who

Because they do not live for themselves.

yǐ	qí	bù	zì	shēng
以	其	不	自	生
by-means-of	their	not	self	live

Thus they can live long.

gù	néng	cháng	shēng
故	能	長	生
therefore	can	long	live

Therefore the sage:

shì	yǐ	shèng	rén
是	以	聖	人
this	thus	sage	person

Puts self last but ends up in front.

hòu	qí	shēn	ér	shēn	xiān
後	其	身	而	身	先
behind	their	body	yet	body	ahead

Puts self outside but self remains.

wài	qí	shēn	ér	shēn	cún
外	其	身	而	身	存
outside	their	body	yet	body	exists

Is it not because they have no self-interest?

fēi	yǐ	qí	wú	sī	xié
非	以	其	無	私	邪
is-not	by-means-of	their	without	private	question

Therefore they can fulfill their own interests.

gù	néng	chéng	qí	sī
故	能	成	其	私
therefore	can	accomplish	their	private

Chapter 8

The highest excellence is like water.

shàng	shàn	ruò	shuǐ
上	善	若	水
highest	excellence	like	water

Water benefits the myriad things without striving.

shuǐ	shàn	lì	wàn	wù	ér	bù	zhēng
水	善	利	萬	物	而	不	爭
water	good-at	benefit	ten-thousand	things	yet	not	strive

It dwells in places that people reject.

chǔ	zhòng	rén	zhī	suǒ	wù
處	眾	人	之	所	惡
dwelt	many	people	of	that-which	reject

Thus it is close to the Way.

gù	jī	yú	dào	
故	幾	於	道	矣
therefore	near	to	way	indeed

In dwelling, it excels in choosing the right place.

jū	shàn	dì
居	善	地
dwelling	excel-in	place

In mind, it excels in depth.

xīn	shàn	yuān
心	善	淵
mind	excel-in	depth

In giving, it excels in benevolence.

yǔ	shàn	rén
與	善	仁
giving	excel-in	benevolence

In speaking, it excels in truthfulness.

yán	shàn	xìn
言	善	信
speech	excel-in	truth

In governance, it excels in order.

zhèng	shàn	zhì
正	善	治
govern	excel-in	order

In affairs, it excels in capability.

shì	shàn	néng
事	善	能
affairs	excel-in	ability

In movement, it excels in timing.

dòng	shàn	shí
動	善	時
movement	excel-in	timing

It is precisely because it does not contend.

fú	wéi	bù	zhēng
夫	唯	不	爭
indeed	only	not	contend

Therefore it meets no resistance.

gù	wú	yóu
故	無	尤
therefore	without	blame

Chapter 9

When you hold and fill something to the brim

chí	ér	yíng	zhī
持	而	盈	之
hold	and	fill-full	it

Better to stop before it overflows

bù	rú	qí	yǐ
不	如	其	已
not	like	its	stop

When you sharpen something to a point

chuái	ér	ruì	zhī
揣	而	銳	之
measure	and	sharp	it

The edge cannot be preserved long

bù	kě	cháng	bǎo
不	可	長	保
not	can	long	maintain

When gold and jade fill your halls

jīn	yù	mǎn	táng
金	玉	滿	堂
gold	jade	fill	hall

No one can protect them

mò	zhī	néng	shǒu
莫	之	能	守
none	it	can	guard

When wealth and status breed arrogance

fù	guì	ér	jiāo
富	貴	而	驕
wealth	honor	and	pride

You bring about your own downfall

zì	yí	qí	jiù
自	遺	其	咎
self	leave	its	blame

When work is done, it is time to retire

gōng	sù	shēn	tù
功	遂	身	退
merit	complete	body	withdraw

This is the Way of Heaven

tiān	zhī	dào
天	之	道
heaven	of	way

Chapter 10

In carrying the spiritual and physical souls while embracing the One

zài	yíng	pò	bào	yī
載	營	魄	抱	一
carry	manage	soul	embrace	one

Can you prevent them from separating?

néng	wú	lí	hū
能	無	離	乎
can	not	separate	question

In concentrating your vital breath to achieve softness

zhuān	qì	zhì	róu
專	氣	致	柔
concentrate	breath	achieve	soft

Can you be like a newborn child?

néng	yīng	ér	hū
能	嬰	兒	乎
can	infant	child	question

In cleansing your inner vision

dī	chú	xuán	lǎn
滌	除	玄	覽
cleansc	remove	mysterious	view

Can you be without flaw?

néng	wú	cǐ	hū
能	無	疵	乎
can	not	flaw	question

In loving the people and governing the state

ài	mín	zhì	guó
愛	民	治	國
love	people	govern	state

Can you practice non-action?

néng	wú	wéi	hū
能	無	為	乎
can	not	act	question

As Heaven's gates open and close

tiān	mén	kāi	hé
天	門	開	闔
heaven	gate	open	close

Can you play the female part?

néng	wéi	cí	hū
能	為	雌	乎
can	act-as	female	question

When understanding reaches in all directions

míng	bái	sì	dá
明	白	四	達
bright	clear	four	reach

Can you be without knowledge?

néng	wú	yǐ	zhī	hū
能	無	以	知	乎
can	not	by-means-of	know	question

Give birth to them and nourish them

shēng	zhī	xù	zhī
生	之	畜	之
give-birth	them	nourish	them

Give birth but do not possess

shēng	ér	bù	yǒu
生	而	不	有
give-birth	yet	not	possess

Act but do not rely on

wéi	ér	bù	shì
為	而	不	恃
act	yet	not	rely-on

Lead but do not dominate

zhǎng	ér	bù	zǎi
長	而	不	宰
lead	yet	not	control

This is called mysterious virtue

shì	wèi	xuán	dé
是	謂	玄	德
this	called	mysterious	virtue

Chapter 11

Thirty spokes join together in one hub

sān	shí	fú	gòng	yī	gū
三	十	輻	共	一	轂
three	ten	spokes	share	one	hub

It is the empty space that makes the wheel useful.

dāng	qí	wú	yǒu	chē	zhī	yòng
當	其	無	有	車	之	用
precisely	its	nothing	exists	wheel	of	use

Clay is molded to make vessels

shān	zhī	yǐ	wéi	qì
埴	埴	以	為	器
knead	clay	by-means-of	make	vessel

It is the empty space that makes the vessel useful.

dāng	qí	wú	yǒu	qì	zhī	yòng
當	其	無	有	器	之	用
precisely	its	nothing	exists	vessel	of	use

Cut out doors and windows to make a room

zào	hù	yǒu	yǐ	wéi	shì
鑿	戶	牖	以	為	室
cut	door	window	by-means-of	make	room

It is the empty space that makes the room useful.

dāng	qí	wú	yǒu	shì	zhī	yòng
當	其	無	有	室	之	用
precisely	its	nothing	exists	room	of	use

Therefore, what exists serves for possession

gù	yǒu	zhī	yǐ	wéi	lì
故	有	之	以	為	利
therefore	exist	it	by-means-of	make	benefit

And what is empty serves for usefulness.

wú	zhī	yǐ	wéi	yòng
無	之	以	為	用
nothing	it	by-means-of	make	use

Chapter 12

The five colors blind people's eyes.

wǔ	sè	lǐng	rén	mù	máng
五	色	令	人	目	盲
five	colors	cause	person	eye	blind

The five tones deafen people's ears.

wǔ	yīn	lǐng	rén	ěr	lóng
五	音	令	人	耳	聾
five	tones	cause	person	ear	deaf

The five flavors dull people's taste.

wǔ	wèi	lǐng	rén	kǒu	shuǎng
五	味	令	人	口	爽
five	flavors	cause	person	mouth	numb

Racing and hunting drive people's minds mad.

chí	chéng	tián	liè	lǐng	rén	xīn	fā	kuáng
馳	騁	畋	獵	令	人	心	發	狂
gallop	run	hunt	hunt	cause	person	heart	become	mad

Rare treasures lead people to harmful behaviors.

nán	dé	zhī	huò	lǐng	rén	xíng	fāng
難	得	之	貨	令	人	行	妨
difficult	obtain	of	goods	cause	person	conduct	harmful

Therefore the sage:

shì	yǐ	shèng	rén
是	以	聖	人
this	by-means-of	sage	person

Acts for the belly and not for the eyes.

wéi	fù	bù	wéi	mù
為	腹	不	為	目
act-for	belly	not	act-for	eyes

Thus rejects that and chooses this.

gù	qù	bǐ	qǔ	cǐ
故	去	彼	取	此
therefore	reject	that	choose	this

Chapter 13

Honor and disgrace are like sudden shocks.

chǒng	rù	ruò	jīng
寵	辱	若	驚
favor	disgrace	like	startle

Value great trouble as you do your body.

guì	dà	huàn	ruò	shēn
貴	大	患	若	身
value	great	trouble	like	body

What does it mean that honor and disgrace are like sudden shocks?

hé	wèi	chǒng	rù	ruò	jīng
何	謂	寵	辱	若	驚
what	mean	favor	disgrace	like	startle

When favor is received from below, it startles.

chǒng	wéi	xià	dé	zhī	ruò	jīng
寵	為	下	得	之	若	驚
favor	be	below	obtain	it	like	startle

When it is lost, it startles.

shī	zhī	ruò	jīng
失	之	若	驚
lose	it	like	startle

This is what is meant by honor and disgrace being like sudden shocks.

shì	wèi	chōng	rù	ruò	jīng
是	謂	寵	辱	若	驚
this	mean	favor	disgrace	like	startle

What does it mean to value great trouble as you do your body?

hé	wèi	guì	dà	huàn	ruò	shēn
何	謂	貴	大	患	若	身
what	mean	value	great	trouble	like	body

The reason I have great trouble is because I have a body.

wú	suǒyī	yǒu	dà	huàn	zhě	wéi	wú
吾	所以	有	大	患	者	為	吾
I	reason	have	great	trouble	that-which	because	I
yǒu	shēn						
有	身						
have	body						

If I had no body, what trouble would I have?

jí	wú	wú	shēn	wú	yǒu	hé	huàn	
及	吾	無	身	吾	有	何	患	。
if	I	not-have	body	I	have	what	trouble	。

Therefore, one who values the world as he does his body may be entrusted with the world.

gù	guì	yǐ	shēn	wéi	tiānxià
。故	貴	以	身	為	天下
therefore	value	by-means-of	body	for	all-under-heaven

One who can be entrusted with the world.

ruò	kě	yǐ	jì	tiānxià	yī
若	可	以	寄	天下	矣
if	can	by-means-of	entrust	all-under-heaven	indeed

One who loves the world as he does his body may be given the world.

ài	yǐ	shēn	wéi	tiānxià
愛	以	身	為	天下
love	by-means-of	body	for	all-under-heaven

One who can be trusted with the world.

ruò	kě	yǐ	tuō	tiānxià	yī
若	可	以	託	天下	矣
if	can	by-means-of	trust	all-under-heaven	indeed

Chapter 14

Looking at it, it cannot be seen - it is called 'subtle'

shì	zhī	bù	jiàn	míng	yuē	yī
視	之	不	見	名	曰	夷
look-at	it	not	see	name	say	subtle

Listening for it, it cannot be heard - it is called 'rare'

tīng	zhī	bù	wén	míng	yuē	xī
聽	之	不	聞	名	曰	希
listen	it	not	hear	name	say	rare

Grasping for it, it cannot be caught - it is called 'minute'

bó	zhī	bù	dé	míng	yuē	wēi
搏	之	不	得	名	曰	微
grasp	it	not	obtain	name	say	minute

These three cannot be further explored

cǐ	sān	zhě	bù	kě	zhì	jié
此	三	者	不	可	致	詰
these	three	ones	not	can	thoroughly	examine

Therefore they merge and become one

gù	hùn	ér	wéi	yī
故	混	而	為	一
therefore	blend	and	become	one

As for this one

yī	zhě
一	者
one	that-which

Its above is not bright

qí	shàng	bù	jiǎo
其	上	不	皦
its	above	not	bright

Its below is not dark

qí	xià	bù	mèi
其	下	不	昧
its	below	not	dark

Continuous and unnameable

shéng	shéng	xī	bù	kě	míng
繩	繩	兮	不	可	名
continuous	continuous	indeed	not	can	name

Returning again to nothingness

fù	guī	yú	wú	wù
復	歸	於	無	物
return	return	to	nothing	thing

This is called the formless form

shì	wèi	wú	zhuàng	zhī	zhuàng
是	謂	無	狀	之	狀
this	called	without	form	of	form

The image of nothingness

wú	wù	zhī	xiàng
無	物	之	象
without	thing	of	image

This is called the vague and elusive

shì	wèi	hū	huǎng
是	謂	惚	恍
this	called	vague	elusive

Meeting it, you cannot see its head

yíng	zhī	bù	jiàn	qí	shǒu
迎	之	不	見	其	首
meet	it	not	see	its	head

Following it, you cannot see its back

suí	zhī	bù	jiàn	qí	hòu
隨	之	不	見	其	後
follow	it	not	see	its	behind

Hold to the ancient Way

zhí	gǔ	zhī	dào
執	古	之	道
hold	ancient	of	way

To master present existence

yǐ	yù	jīn	zhī	yǒu
以	御	今	之	有
by-means-of	master	present	of	existence

Being able to know the ancient beginning

néng	zhī	gǔ	shǐ
能	知	古	始
able	know	ancient	beginning

This is called the thread of the Way

shì	wèi	dào	jì
是	謂	道	紀
this	called	way	thread

Chapter 15

The ancient masters of the Way were subtle, mysterious, and profoundly penetrating.

gǔ	zhī	shàn	wéi	shì	zhě	wēi	miào
古	之	善	為	士	者	微	妙
ancient	of	good-at	acting-as	master	one-who	subtle	mysterious
xuán	tōng						
玄	通						
profound	penetrating						

Their depth was beyond comprehension.

shēn	bù	kě	shí
深	不	可	識
deep	not	can	know

Because they were beyond comprehension,

fú	wéi	bù	kě	shí
夫	唯	不	可	識
thus	only	not	can	know

I can only describe their appearance.

gù	qiáng	wéi	zhī	róng
故	強	為	之	容
therefore	force	make	their	appearance

Cautious, like crossing a winter stream.

yù	xī	ruò	dōng	shè	chuān
豫	兮	若	冬	涉	川
cautious	!	like	winter	crossing	stream

Vigilant, like one wary of neighbors on all sides.

yóu	xī	ruò	wèi	sì	lín
猶	兮	若	畏	四	鄰
hesitant	!	like	fear	four	neighbors

Dignified, like a guest.

yǎn	xī	qí	ruò	kè
儼	兮	其	若	客
dignified	!	it	like	guest

Yielding, like ice about to melt.

huàn	xī	ruò	bīng	—	jiāng	shì
渙	兮	若	冰	—	將	釋
dissolving	!	like	ice		about-to	melt

Simple, like uncarved wood.

dūn	xī	qí	ruò	pǔ
敦	兮	其	若	樸
honest	!	it	like	uncarved-wood

Open, like a valley.

kuàng	xī	qí	ruò	gǔ
曠	兮	其	若	谷
vast	!	it	like	valley

Merged, like murky water.

hùn	xī	qí	ruò	zhuó
混	兮	其	若	濁
merged	!	it	like	murky

Who can make the murky gradually clear through stillness?

shú	néng	zhuó	yǐ	jìng	zhī	xú	qīng
孰	能	濁	以	靜	之	徐	清
who	can	murky	by-means-of	still	it	gradually	clear

Who can bring life through gradual movement from stillness?

shú	néng	ān	yǐ	jiǔ	dòng	zhī	xú
孰	能	安	以	久	動	之	徐
who	can	peaceful	by-means-of	long	movement	it	gradually
shēng							
生							
live							

Those who preserve this Way do not desire fullness.

bǎo	cǐ	dào	zhě	bù	yù	yíng
保	此	道	者	不	欲	盈
preserve	this	way	one-who	not	desire	full

It is because they are not full,

fú	wéi	bù	yíng
夫	唯	不	盈
thus	only	not	full

That they can remain hidden and be made anew.

shì	yǐ	néng	bì	ér	bù		chéng
是	以	能	蔽	而	不	—	成
this	by-means-of	can	hide	and	not		complete

Chapter 16

Achieve utmost emptiness.

zhì	xū	jí
致	虛	極
achieve	empty	utmost

Maintain profound quietude.

shǒu	jìng	dū
守	靜	篤
maintain	quiet	profound

The ten thousand things arise together.

wàn	wù	bìng	zuò
萬	物	並	作
ten-thousand	things	together	arise

I thereby observe their return.

wú	yǐ	guān	qí	fù
吾	以	觀	其	復
I	by-means-of	observe	their	return

Now, all things flourish abundantly, each returning to its root.

fú	wù	yúnyún	gè	fù	guī	qí	gēn
夫	物	芸芸	各	復	歸	其	根
now	things	abundant	each	return	return-to	its	root

Returning to the root is called quietude.

gui	gēn	yuē	jìng
歸	根	曰	靜
return-to	root	called	quiet

This quietude is called returning to one's destiny.

jìng	shì	wèi	fù	mìng
靜	是	謂	復	命
quietude	this	called	return	destiny

Returning to destiny is called constancy.

fù	mìng	yuē	cháng
復	命	曰	常
return	destiny	called	constant

Knowing constancy is called enlightenment.

zhī	cháng	yuē	míng
知	常	曰	明
know	constant	called	bright

Not knowing constancy leads to reckless action and misfortune.

bù	zhī	cháng	wàng	zuò	xiōng
不	知	常	妄	作	凶
not	know	constant	reckless	act	misfortune

Knowing constancy leads to capacity.

zhī	cháng	róng
知	常	容
know	constant	capacity

Capacity leads to inclusiveness.

róng	nǎi	gōng
容	乃	公
capacity	leads-to	inclusive

Inclusiveness leads to kingliness.

gōng	nǎi	wáng
公	乃	王
inclusive	leads-to	king

Kingliness leads to heaven.

wáng	nǎi	tiān
王	乃	天
king	leads-to	heaven

Heaven leads to the Way.

tiān	nǎi	dào
天	乃	道
heaven	leads-to	way

The Way leads to endurance.

dào	nǎi	jiǔ
道	乃	久
way	leads-to	enduring

Until the end of one's life, there is no danger.

mò	shēn	bù	dài
沒	身	不	殆
end	body	not	danger

Chapter 17

Of the highest rulers, those below merely know they exist.

tài	shàng	xià	zhī	yǒu	zhī
太	上	下	知	有	之
supreme	highest	below	know	exist	them

The next best are loved and praised.

qí	cì	qīn	ér	yù	zhī
其	次	親	而	譽	之
their	next	close-to	and	praise	them

The next are feared.

qí	cì	wèi	zhī
其	次	畏	之
their	next	fear	them

The next are despised.

qí	cì	wù	zhī
其	次	侮	之
their	next	despise	them

When trust is insufficient, there arises distrust.

xìn	bù	zú	yān	yǒu	bù	xìn	—
信	不	足	焉	有	不	信	
trust	not	sufficient	therein	exist	not	trust	

How careful they are with their words!

yóu	xī	qí	guì	yán
猶	兮	其	貴	言
hesitate	ah	their	value	words

When the work is completed and tasks accomplished,

gōng	chéng	shì	suí
功	成	事	遂
achievement	complete	affairs	follow

The common people all say, 'We did this naturally.'

bǎi	xìng	jiē	wèi	wǒ	zì	rán
百	姓	皆	謂	我	自	然
hundred	surnames	all	say	we	self	so

Chapter 18

When the great Way is abandoned,

dà dào fèi
大 道 廢
great way abandoned

There arise benevolence and righteousness.

yǒu rén-yì
有 仁義
exist benevolence-righteousness

When cleverness emerges,

huì-zhì chū
慧智 出
wisdom-intelligence emerge

There arises great pretense.

yǒu dà wěi
有 大 偽
exist great falsehood

When the six family relationships are not in harmony,

liù qīn bù hé
六 親 不 和
six relations not harmonious

There arise filial piety and compassion.

yǒu	xiào	cí
有	孝	慈
exist	filial-piety	compassion

When the country falls into chaos,

guó	jiā	hūn	luàn
國	家	昏	亂
country	family	confused	chaos

There arise loyal ministers.

yǒu	zhōng	chén
有	忠	臣
exist	loyal	minister

Chapter 19

Abandon sagacity, discard knowledge

jué	shèng	qì	zhì
絕	聖	棄	智
cut-off	sagacity	abandon	wisdom

And the people will benefit a hundredfold

mín	lì	bǎi	bèi
民	利	百	倍
people	benefit	hundred	times

Abandon benevolence, discard righteousness

jué	rén	qì	yì
絕	仁	棄	義
cut-off	benevolence	abandon	righteousness

And the people will return to filial piety and compassion

mín	fù	xiào	cí
民	復	孝	慈
people	return	filial	compassion

Abandon cleverness, discard profit

jué	qiǎo	qì	lì
絕	巧	棄	利
cut-off	cleverness	abandon	profit

And thieves and robbers will disappear

dào	zéi	wú	yǒu
盜	賊	無	有
thief	bandit	not	exist

These three things are ornamental and thus inadequate

cǐ	sān	zhě	yǐ	wéi	wén	bù	zú
此	三	者	以	為	文	不	足
these	three	ones	by-means-of	make	culture	not	enough

Therefore ensure there are these to embrace

gù	lǐng	yǒu	suǒ	shǔ
故	令	有	所	屬
therefore	cause	have	that-which	belong

See the plain

jiàn	sù
見	素
see	plain

Embrace simplicity

bào	pǔ
抱	樸
embrace	simplicity

Lessen self-interest

shǎo	sī
少	私
decrease	private

Reduce desires

guǎ	yù
寡	欲
few	desire

Chapter 20

Abandon learning and there will be no sorrow.

jué	xué	wú	yōu
絕	學	無	憂
cut-off	learning	without	worry

Between 'yes' and 'yeah', how much difference is there?

wéi	zhī	yǔ	ā
唯	之	與	阿
yes	of	and	yeah

How far apart are they?

xiāng	qù	jǐ	hé
相	去	幾	何
mutually	separate	how-much	what

Between good and evil, how much difference is there?

měi	zhī	yǔ	è
美	之	與	惡
good	of	and	evil

How far apart are they?

xiāng	qù	ruò	hé
相	去	若	何
mutually	separate	like	what

What others fear, one must also fear.

rén	zhī	suǒ	wèi	bù	kě	bù	wèi
人	之	所	畏	不	可	不	畏
people	of	that-which	fear	not	can	not	fear

How boundless it seems!

huāng	xī	qí	wèi	yāng	zāi
荒	兮	其	未	央	哉
wild	ah	it	not-yet	end	indeed

The masses are joyous and merry.

zhòng	rén	xī	xī
眾	人	熙	熙
many	people	bright	bright

As if enjoying a great feast.

rú	xiǎng	tài	láo
如	享	太	牢
like	enjoy	great	sacrifice

As if ascending a terrace in spring.

rú	chūn	dēng	tái
如	春	登	臺
like	spring	climb	terrace

I alone am still and unmoving.

wǒ	dú	bó	xī
我	獨	泊	兮
I	alone	still	ah

Like an infant who has not yet smiled.

qí	wèi	zhào
其	未	兆
it	not-yet	show-sign

Like a newborn who has not yet smiled.

rú	yīng	ér	zhī	wèi	hái
如	嬰	兒	之	未	孩
like	infant	child	of	not-yet	smile

Weary, as though having no home to return to.

lěi	lěi	xī	ruò	wú	suǒ	guī
僂	僂	兮	若	無	所	歸
tired	tired	ah	like	no	place	return

The masses all have more than enough.

zhòng	rén	jiē	yǒu	yú
眾	人	皆	有	餘
many	people	all	have	excess

I alone appear to be lacking.

—	wó	dú	ruò	yí
	我	獨	若	遺
	I	alone	like	lost

Mine is indeed the mind of a fool.

wó	yú	rén	zhī	xīn	yě	zài
我	愚	人	之	心	也	哉
I	foolish	person	of	heart	indeed	indeed

So muddled!

dùn	dùn	xī
沌	沌	兮
chaos	chaos	ah

Common people are bright.

sú	rén	zhāo	zhāo
俗	人	昭	昭
common	people	bright	bright

I alone am dim.

wó	dú	ruò	hūn
我	獨	若	昏
I	alone	like	dark

Common people are discriminating.

sú	rén	chá	chá
俗	人	察	察
common	people	examine	examine

I alone am muddled.

wǒ	dú	mèn	mèn
我	獨	悶	悶
I	alone	depressed	depressed

Boundless like the sea.

dàn	xī	qí	ruò	hǎi
澹	兮	其	若	海
calm	ah	it	like	sea

Drifting as if with nowhere to rest.

piāo	xī	ruò	wú	suǒ	zhǐ
漂	兮	若	無	所	止
drift	ah	like	no	place	stop

The masses all have their purpose.

zhòng	rén	jiē	yǒu	yǐ
眾	人	皆	有	以
many	people	all	have	by-means-of

I alone am stubborn and uncouth.

—	wó	dú	wán	sì	bǐ
	我	獨	頑	似	鄙
	I	alone	stubborn	seem	vulgar

I alone differ from others.

wǒ	dú	yì	yú	rén
我	獨	異	於	人
I	alone	different	from	people

And value drawing sustenance from the Mother.

ér	guì	shí	mǔ
而	貴	食	母
and	value	feed	mother

Chapter 21

The manifestation of great virtue follows only the Dao.

kǒng	dé	zhī	róng	wéi	dào	shì	cóng
孔	德	之	容	唯	道	是	從
great	virtue	of	appearance	only	way	is	follow

The Dao as a thing is but vague and elusive.

dào	zhī	wéi	wù	wéi	huāng	wéi	hū
道	之	為	物	唯	恍	唯	惚
way	of	as	thing	only	vague	only	indistinct

Indistinct and vague, yet within it there are images.

hū	xī	huāng	xī	qí	zhōng	yǒu	xiàng
惚	兮	恍	兮	其	中	有	象
indistinct	ah	vague	ah	its	within	have	image

Vague and indistinct, yet within it there are things.

huāng	xī	hū	xī	qí	zhōng	yǒu	wù
恍	兮	惚	兮	其	中	有	物
vague	ah	indistinct	ah	its	within	have	thing

Deep and dark, yet within it there is essence.

yǎo	xī	míng	xī	qí	zhōng	yǒu	jīng
窈	兮	冥	兮	其	中	有	精
deep	ah	dark	ah	its	within	have	essence

This essence is very real.

qí	jīng	shèn	zhēn
其	精	甚	真
its	essence	very	real

Within it there is truth.

qí	zhōng	yǒu	xìn
其	中	有	信
its	within	have	truth

From ancient times until now,

zì	jīn	jí	gǔ
自	今	及	古
from	present	reach	ancient

Its name has never departed.

qí	míng	bù	qù
其	名	不	去
its	name	not	depart

Through it we observe all beginnings.

yǐ	yuè	zhòng	fū
以	閱	眾	甫
by-means-of	examine	many	beginning

How do I know the nature of all beginnings?

wú	hé	yǐ	zhī	zhòng	fù	zhī	rán	zāi
吾	何	以	知	眾	甫	之	然	哉
I	how	by-means-of	know	many	beginning	of	thus	indeed

Through this.

yǐ	cǐ
以	此
by-means-of	this

Chapter 22

What is bent becomes whole.

qū	zé	quán
曲	則	全
bent	then	complete

What is crooked becomes straight.

wǎng	zé	zhí
枉	則	直
crooked	then	straight

What is empty becomes full.

wā	zé	yíng
窪	則	盈
hollow	then	full

What is worn becomes new.

bì	zé	xīn
敝	則	新
worn	then	new

With little, one gains.

shǎo	zé	dé
少	則	得
little	then	gain

With much, one becomes confused.

duō	zé	huò
多	則	惑
much	then	confused

Therefore the sage

shì	yǐ	shèng	rén
是	以	聖	人
this	by-means-of	sage	person

Embraces the One as the model for all under heaven

bào	yī	yī	wéi	tiān-xià	shì
抱	一	以	為	天下	式
embrace	one	by-means-of	become	under-heaven	model

Not displaying self, thus bright

bù	zì	jiàn	gù	míng
不	自	見	故	明
not	self	show	therefore	bright

Not asserting self, thus distinct

bù	zì	shì	gù	zhāng
不	自	是	故	彰
not	self	right	therefore	distinct

Not boasting, thus meritorious

bù	zì	fá	gù	yǒu	gōng
不	自	伐	故	有	功
not	self	boast	therefore	have	merit

Not being prideful, thus lasting

bù	zì	jīn	gù	cháng
不	自	矜	故	長
not	self	pride	therefore	long

It is because one does not contend

fú	wéi	bù	zhēng
夫	唯	不	爭
indeed	only	not	contend

Therefore none under heaven can contend with them

gù	tiān-xià	mò	néng	yǔ	zhī	zhēng
故	天下	莫	能	與	之	爭
therefore	under-heaven	none	can	with	them	contend

The ancient saying

gǔ	zhī	suǒ	wèi
古	之	所	謂
ancient	of	that-which	called

'The bent becomes whole'

qū	zé	quán	zhě
曲	則	全	者
bent	then	complete	one-who

How could these be empty words?

qǐ	xū	yán	zài
豈	虛	言	哉
how	empty	words	indeed

Truly, become whole and return to it.

chéng	quán	ér	guī	zhī
誠	全	而	歸	之
truly	complete	and	return	to-it

Chapter 23

Sparse words are natural.

xī	yán	zì	rán
希	言	自	然
sparse	words	self	so

Therefore, a whirlwind does not last all morning,

gù	piāo	fēng	bù	zhōng	zhāo
• 故	飄	風	不	終	朝
therefore	whirling	wind	not	end	morning

A sudden rain does not last all day.

zhòu	yǔ	bù	zhōng	rì
驟	雨	不	終	日
sudden	rain	not	end	day

Who creates these? Heaven and Earth.

shú	wéi	cǐ	zhě	tiān	dì
孰	為	此	者	天	地
who	make	these	one-who	heaven	earth

Even Heaven and Earth cannot make them last long,

tiān	dì	shàng	bù	néng	jiǔ
天	地	尚	不	能	久
heaven	earth	even	not	can	long

How much less can humans?

ér kuàng yú rén hū
而 況 於 人 乎 •
and moreover to human question

Therefore, those who follow the Way,

gù cóng shì yú dào zhě
• 故 從 事 於 道 者
therefore follow affairs to way one-who

Those of the Way align with the Way.

dào zhě tóng yú dào
道 者 同 於 道
way one-who align with way

Those of virtue align with virtue.

dé zhě tóng yú dé
德 者 同 於 德
virtue one-who align with virtue

Those of loss align with loss.

shī zhě tóng yú shī
失 者 同 於 失
loss one-who align with loss

Those who align with the Way,

tóng	yú	dào	zhě
同	於	道	者
align	with	way	one-who

The Way joyfully accepts them.

dào	yì	lè	dé	zhī
道	亦	樂	得	之
way	also	joy	obtain	them

Those who align with virtue,

tóng	yú	dé	zhě
同	於	德	者
align	with	virtue	one-who

Virtue joyfully accepts them.

dé	yì	lè	dé	zhī
德	亦	樂	得	之
virtue	also	joy	obtain	them

Those who align with loss,

tóng	yú	shī	zhě
同	於	失	者
align	with	loss	one-who

Loss joyfully accepts them.

shī	yì	lè	dé	zhī
失	亦	樂	得	之
loss	also	joy	obtain	them

When trust is insufficient, there exists distrust.

xìn	bù	zú	yān	yǒu	bù	xìn	—
信	不	足	焉	有	不	信	
trust	not	sufficient	therein	exist	not	trust	

Chapter 24

One who stands on tiptoe cannot stand firm.

qǐ	zhě	bù	lì
企	者	不	立
tiptoe	one-who	not	stand

One who strides cannot walk far.

kuà	zhě	bù	xíng
跨	者	不	行
stride	one-who	not	walk

One who displays himself does not shine.

zì	jiàn	zhě	bù	míng
自	見	者	不	明
self	see	one-who	not	bright

One who asserts himself is not distinguished.

zì	shì	zhě	bù	zhāng
自	是	者	不	彰
self	right	one-who	not	manifest

One who boasts of himself achieves no merit.

zì	fā	zhě	wú	gōng
自	伐	者	無	功
self	boast	one-who	without	merit

One who is proud of himself does not endure.

zì	jīn	zhě	bù	cháng
自	矜	者	不	長
self	pride	one-who	not	endure

In relation to the Way, these are called:

qí	zài	dào	yě
其	在	道	也
it	in	way	indeed

Excess food and unnecessary actions.

yuē	yú	shí	zhuì	xíng
曰	餘	食	贅	行
called	excess	food	superfluous	action

Such things are despised by all creatures.

wù	huò	wù	zhī
物	或	惡	之
things	perhaps	despise	them

Therefore, one who follows the Way does not dwell in them.

gù	yǒu	dào	zhě	bù	chǔ
故	有	道	者	不	處
therefore	have	way	one-who	not	dwell

Chapter 25

There was something formed in chaos

yǒu	wù	hùn	chéng
有	物	混	成
exists	thing	chaos	complete

Born before Heaven and Earth

xiān	tiān	dì	shēng
先	天	地	生
before	heaven	earth	born

Silent and void

jì	xī	liáo	xī
寂	兮	寥	兮
silent	!	void	!

Standing alone and unchanging

dú	lì	bù	gǎi
獨	立	不	改
alone	stand	not	change

Circulating endlessly without danger

zhōu	xíng	ér	bù	dài
周	行	而	不	殆
cycle	move	and	not	danger

It can be regarded as the mother of all under heaven

kě	yǐ	wéi	tiān	xià	mǔ
可	以	為	天	下	母
can	by-means-of	be	heaven	below	mother

I do not know its name

wú	bù	zhī	qí	míng
吾	不	知	其	名
I	not	know	its	name

Designating it, I call it Dao

zì	zhī	yuē	dào
字	之	曰	道
designate	it	say	way

Forced to give it a name, I call it Great

qiáng	wéi	zhī	míng	yuē	dà
強	為	之	名	曰	大
force	make	it	name	say	great

Great means passing beyond

dà	yuē	shì
大	曰	逝
great	say	passing

Passing beyond means far-reaching

shì	yuē	yuǎn
逝	曰	遠
passing	say	far

Far-reaching means returning

yuǎn	yuē	fǎn
遠	曰	反
far	say	return

Therefore, the Dao is great

	dào	dà
—	道	大
	way	great

Heaven is great

tiān	dà
天	大
heaven	great

Earth is great

dì	dà
地	大
earth	great

The ruler is also great

wáng	yì	dà
王	亦	大
ruler	also	great

Within the realm there are four greats

yù	zhōng	yǒu	sì	dà
域	中	有	四	大
realm	within	exist	four	great

And the ruler occupies one of them

ér	wáng	jū	qí	yī	yān
而	王	居	其	一	焉
and	ruler	occupy	its	one	thereof

Humans follow Earth

rén	fǎ	dì
人	法	地
human	model	earth

Earth follows Heaven

dì	fǎ	tiān
地	法	天
earth	model	heaven

Heaven follows the Dao

tiān	fǎ	dào
天	法	道
heaven	model	way

The Dao follows what is natural

dào	fǎ	zì	rán
道	法	自	然
way	model	self	so

Chapter 26

Heaviness is the root of lightness.

zhòng	wéi	qīng	gēn
重	為	輕	根
heavy	becomes	light	root

Stillness is the master of restlessness.

jìng	wéi	zào	jūn
靜	為	躁	君
still	becomes	restless	ruler

Therefore the noble person throughout the day

shì	yǐ	jūnzǐ	zhōng	rì
是	以	君子	終	日
this	by-means-of	noble-person	throughout	day

Travels without leaving their supply wagons.

xíng	bù	lí	qí	zì
行	不	離	其	輜
travel	not	leave	their	wagon

Though there are magnificent sights to see,

zhòng	suī	yǒu	róng	guān	yàn
重	雖	有	榮	觀	燕
heavy	although	have	glory	view	feast

They remain serenely unattached.

chǔ	chāo	rán
處	超	然
dwell	transcend	thus

How can the lord of ten thousand chariots

nài	hé	wàn	shèng	zhī	zhǔ
奈	何	萬	乘	之	主
how	what	ten-thousand	chariots	of	lord

Treat their body lightly in governing the world?

ér	yǐ	shēn	qīng	tiān	xià
而	以	身	輕	天	下
yet	by-means-of	body	light	heaven	below

In lightness, the root is lost.

qīng	zé	shī	bēn
輕	則	失	本
light	then	lose	root

In restlessness, mastery is lost.

zào	zé	shī	jūn
躁	則	失	君
restless	then	lose	ruler

Chapter 27

Good walking leaves no tracks.

shàn	xíng	wú	zhéjī
善	行	無	轍迹
good	walk	without	wheel-tracks

Good speech has no flaws.

shàn	yán	wú	xiázhé
善	言	無	瑕謫
good	speak	without	flaw-blame

Good counting needs no tools.

shàn	shù	bù	yòng	chóucè
善	數	不	用	籌策
good	count	not	use	counting-tools

Good closing needs no bolt or lock, yet cannot be opened.

shàn	bì	wú	guānjiàn	ér	bù	kě	kāi
善	閉	無	關鍵	而	不	可	開
good	close	without	bolt-bar	yet	not	can	open

Good tying uses no rope, yet cannot be untied.

shàn	jié	wú	móyuē	ér	bù	kě	jiě
善	結	無	繆約	而	不	可	解
good	tie	without	rope-bind	yet	not	can	untie

Therefore the sage

shì	yǐ	shèng	rén
是	以	聖	人
this	by-means-of	sage	person

Always is good at saving people

cháng	shàn	jiù	rén
常	善	救	人
always	good-at	save	people

Therefore abandons no one

gù	wú	qì	rén
故	無	棄	人
therefore	without	abandon	person

Always is good at saving things

cháng	shàn	jiù	wù
常	善	救	物
always	good-at	save	things

Therefore abandons nothing.

gù	wú	qì	wù
故	無	棄	物
therefore	without	abandon	things

This is called following the light.

shì	wèi	xí	míng
是	謂	襲	明
this	called	inherit	brightness

Therefore, the good person is the teacher of the not-good person.

gù	shàn	rén	zhě	bù	shàn	rén	zhī	shī
故	善	人	者	不	善	人	之	師
therefore	good	person	one-who	not	good	person	of	teacher

The not-good person is the resource of the good person.

bù	shàn	rén	zhě	shàn	rén	zhī	zī
不	善	人	者	善	人	之	資
not	good	person	one-who	good	person	of	resource

Not valuing one's teacher

bù	guì	qí	shī
不	貴	其	師
not	value	one's	teacher

Not loving one's resource

bù	ài	qí	zī
不	愛	其	資
not	love	one's	resource

Though clever, greatly confused

sui	zhi	dà	mi
雖	智	大	迷
although	wisdom	great	confused

This is called the essential mystery.

shì	wèi	yào	miào
是	謂	要	妙
this	called	essential	mystery

Chapter 28

Know the masculine, but keep to the feminine

zhī	qí	xióng	shǒu	qí	cí
知	其	雄	守	其	雌
know	its	masculine	maintain	its	feminine

Become the stream of the world

wéi	tiān	xià	xī
為	天	下	谿
become	heaven	below	stream

Become the stream of the world

wéi	tiān	xià	xī
為	天	下	谿
become	heaven	below	stream

The constant virtue never departs

cháng	dé	bù	lí
常	德	不	離
constant	virtue	not	depart

Return again to the infant state

fù	guī	yú	yīng	ér
復	歸	於	嬰	兒
return	return-to	to	infant	child

Know the white, but keep to the black

zhī	qí	bái	shǒu	qí	hēi
知	其	白	守	其	黑
know	its	white	maintain	its	black

Become the model for the world

wéi	tiān	xià	shì
為	天	下	式
become	heaven	below	model

Become the model for the world

wéi	tiān	xià	shì
為	天	下	式
become	heaven	below	model

The constant virtue never errs

cháng	dé	bù	tè
常	德	不	忒
constant	virtue	not	err

Return again to the limitless

fù	guī	yú	wú	jí
復	歸	於	無	極
return	return-to	to	without	limit

Know the glory, but keep to humility

zhī	qí	róng	shǒu	qí	rǔ
知	其	榮	守	其	辱
know	its	glory	maintain	its	humility

Become the valley of the world

wéi	tiān	xià	gǔ
為	天	下	谷
become	heaven	below	valley

Become the valley of the world

wéi	tiān	xià	gǔ
為	天	下	谷
become	heaven	below	valley

The constant virtue is then sufficient

cháng	dé	nǎi	zú
常	德	乃	足
constant	virtue	then	sufficient

Return again to simplicity

fù	guī	yú	pǔ
復	歸	於	樸
return	return-to	to	simplicity

When simplicity is divided, it becomes vessels

pǔ	sàn	zé	wéi	qì
樸	散	則	為	器
simplicity	scatter	then	become	vessel

When the sage uses it, they become leaders

shèng	rén	yòng	zhī	zé	wéi	guān	zhǎng
聖	人	用	之	則	為	官	長
sage	person	use	it	then	become	official	leader

Therefore the great system does not cut apart

gù	dà	zhì	bù	gē
故	大	制	不	割
therefore	great	system	not	cut

Chapter 29

When one desires to take control of the world and act upon it,

jiāng	yù	qǔ	tiān-xià	ér	wéi	zhī
將	欲	取	天下	而	為	之
about-to	desire	take	all-under-heaven	and	do	it

I observe that they will certainly fail.

wú	jiàn	qí	bù	dé	yǐ
吾	見	其	不	得	已
I	see	its	not	obtain	already

For the world is a sacred vessel.

fú	tiān-xià	shén-qì
夫	天下	神器
indeed	all-under-heaven	sacred-vessel

It cannot be acted upon.

bù	kě	wéi	yě
不	可	為	也
not	can	do	indeed

Those who act upon it will ruin it.

wéi	zhě	bài	zhī
為	者	敗	之
do	one-who	ruin	it

Those who grasp it will lose it.

zhí	zhě	shī	zhī
執	者	失	之
grasp	one-who	lose	it

Therefore in all things:

gù	wù
故	物
therefore	things

Some lead, some follow,

huò	xíng	huò	suí
或	行	或	隨
some	walk	some	follow

Some breathe gently, some breathe strongly,

huò	xū	huò	chuī
或	歔	或	吹
some	inhale	some	blow

Some are strong, some are weak,

huò	qiáng	huò	léi
或	強	或	羸
some	strong	some	weak

Some break down, some fall apart.

huò	cuò	huò	huì
或	挫	或	隳
some	break	some	collapse

Therefore the sage:

shì	yǐ	shèng-rén
是	以	聖人
this	by-means-of	sage-person

Eliminates excess,

qù	shèn
去	甚
remove	excessive

Eliminates extravagance,

qù	shē
去	奢
remove	extravagant

Eliminates extremes.

qù	tài
去	泰
remove	extreme

Chapter 30

One who assists a ruler according to the Dao

yí	dào	zuǒ	rén	zhǔ	zhě
以	道	佐	人	主	者
by-means-of	way	assist	person	ruler	one-who

Does not use military force to dominate the world

bù	yǐ	bīng	qiáng	tiān	xià
不	以	兵	強	天	下
not	by-means-of	weapons	force	heaven	below

Such affairs tend to return upon themselves

qí	shì	hǎo	huán
其	事	好	還
its	affairs	tend-to	return

Where armies camp, thorns and brambles grow

shī	zhī	suǒ	chù	jīngjí	shēng
師	之	所	處	荊棘	生
army	of	place	dwel	thorns-brambles	grow

After great armies, years of famine surely follow

yān	dà	jūn	zhī	hòu	bì	yǒu	xiōng	nián
焉	大	軍	之	後	必	有	凶	年
thereupon	great	army	of	after	surely	have	disaster	year

The good achieve their purpose and stop

shàn	zhě	guǒ	ér	yǐ
善	者	果	而	已
good	one-who	result	and	stop

Not daring to take by force

bù	gǎn	yǐ	qǔ	qiáng
不	敢	以	取	強
not	dare	by-means-of	take	force

Achieve results but do not boast

guǒ	ér	wù	jīn
果	而	勿	矜
result	and	do-not	boast

Achieve results but do not brag

guǒ	ér	wù	fá
果	而	勿	伐
result	and	do-not	attack

Achieve results but do not be arrogant

guǒ	ér	wù	jiāo
果	而	勿	驕
result	and	do-not	arrogant

Achieve results because there is no choice

guǒ	ér	bù	dé	yǐ
果	而	不	得	已
result	and	not	obtain	already

Achieve results but do not force

guǒ	ér	wù	qiáng
果	而	勿	強
result	and	do-not	force

Things at their peak must decline

wù	zhuàng	zé	lǎo
物	壯	則	老
things	strong	then	old

This is called not following the Dao

shì	wèi	bù	dào
是	謂	不	道
this	called	not	way

Not following the Dao ends early

bù	dào	zǎo	yǐ
不	道	早	已
not	way	early	end

Chapter 31

Now, fine weapons are instruments of ill omen.

fū	jiā	bīng	zhě	bùxiáng	zhī	qì
夫	佳	兵	者	不祥	之	器
now	fine	weapon	one-who	ill-omen	of	instrument

Some things are detested by all.

wù	huò	wù	zhī
物	或	惡	之
things	perhaps	detest	it

Therefore, those who possess the Way do not dwell with them.

gù	yǒu	dào	zhě	bù	chǔ
故	有	道	者	不	處
therefore	have	way	one-who	not	dwell

The noble one values the left when at home.

jūnzi	jū	zé	guì	zuǒ
君子	居	則	貴	左
noble-one	dwell	then	value	left

In war, one values the right.

yòng	bīng	zé	guì	yòu
用	兵	則	貴	右
use	weapon	then	value	right

Weapons are instruments of ill omen.

bīng	zhě	bùxiáng	zhī	qì
兵	者	不祥	之	器
weapon	one-who	ill-omen	of	instrument

They are not the tools of a noble one.

fēi	jūnzǐ	zhī	qì
非	君子	之	器
not	noble-one	of	instrument

Only when forced will one use them.

bùdéyǐ	ér	yòng	zhī
不得已	而	用	之
no-alternative	and	use	them

Calmness and tranquility are considered best.

tiándàn	wéi	shàng
恬淡	為	上
calm-peaceful	make	supreme

Do not glorify them.

—	—	wù	měi	也
		勿	美	
		do-not	beautify	indeed

Those who glorify them delight in killing people.

ér	měi	zhī	zhě	shì	lè	shā	rén
而	美	之	者	是	樂	殺	人
yet	beautify	them	one-who	is	delight	kill	person

Now, one who delights in killing people

fū	lè	shā	rén	zhě
夫	樂	殺	人	者
now	delight	kill	person	one-who

Cannot achieve their will in the world.

bù	kěyǐ	dézhì	yú	tiānxià	yī	
—	不	可以	得志	於	天下	矣
	not	can	achieve-will	in	under-heaven	indeed

Therefore in auspicious matters, favor the left.

gù	jí	shì	shàng	zuǒ
故	吉	事	尚	左
therefore	auspicious	matter	favor	left

In inauspicious matters, favor the right.

xiōng	shì	shàng	yòu
凶	事	尚	右
inauspicious	matter	favor	right

Thus the lieutenant general stands on the left.

shìyǐ	piān	jiāngjūn	jū	zuǒ
是以	偏	將軍	居	左
thus	lieutenant	general	stands	left

The supreme general stands on the right.

shàng	jiāngjūn	jū	yòu
上	將軍	居	右
supreme	general	stands	right

This means they are placed according to funeral rites.

yán	yǐ	sānglǐ	chǔ	zhī
言	以	喪禮	處	之
speak	by-means-of	funeral-rites	place	them

When many people are killed

shā	rén	zhòng
殺	人	眾
kill	person	many

One should weep for them with sorrow.

yǐ	āi	bēi	qì	zhī
以	哀	悲	泣	之
by-means-of	sorrow	grief	weep	them

Victory in battle should be treated as a funeral.

zhàn	shèng	yǐ	sānglǐ	chù	zhī
戰	勝	以	喪禮	處	之
battle	victory	by-means-of	funeral-rites	treat	it

Chapter 32

The Dao is eternally nameless.

dào	cháng	wú	míng
道	常	無	名
way	constant	without	name

Though the uncarved block is small,

pǔ	suī	xiǎo
樸	雖	小
uncarved-block	although	small

None under heaven can subordinate it.

tiān	xià	mò	néng	chén	—
天	下	莫	能	臣	
heaven	below	none	can	subordinate	

If lords and kings could preserve it,

hóu	wáng	ruò	néng	shǒu	zhī
侯	王	若	能	守	之
lords	kings	if	can	preserve	it

The ten thousand things would submit naturally.

wàn	wù	jiāng	zì	bīn
萬	物	將	自	賓
ten-thousand	things	will	self	submit

Heaven and Earth combine,

tiān	dì	xiāng	hé
天	地	相	合
heaven	earth	mutually	join

To send down sweet dew.

yǐ	jiàng	gān	lù
以	降	甘	露
by-means-of	descend	sweet	dew

Without command, people naturally become equal.

mín	mò	zhī	lìng
民	莫	之	令
people	none	it	command

Yet naturally achieve harmony.

ér	zì	jūn
而	自	均
yet	self	equal

When order begins, names arise.

yān	shǐ	zhì	yǒu	míng
焉	始	制	有	名
thereupon	begin	system	have	name

Once names exist,

míng	yì	jì	yǒu
名	亦	既	有
name	also	already	have

One must know when to stop.

fū	yì	jiāng	zhī	zhǐ
夫	亦	將	知	止
then	also	will	know	stop

Knowing when to stop prevents danger.

zhī	zhǐ	suǒ	yǐ	bù	dài
知	止	所	以	不	殆
know	stop	that-which	by-means-of	not	danger

The Dao in the world,

pì	dào	zhī	zài	tiān	xià
譬	道	之	在	天	下
compare	way	of	exist	heaven	below

Is like streams and valleys flowing into rivers and seas.

yóu	chuān	gǔ	zhī	yǔ	jiāng	hǎi
猶	川	谷	之	與	江	海
like	streams	valleys	of	and	rivers	seas

Chapter 33

One who knows others is wise.

zhī	rén	zhě	zhì
知	人	者	智
know	others	one-who	wise

One who knows oneself has clarity.

zì	zhī	zhě	míng
自	知	者	明
self	know	one-who	bright

One who overcomes others has force.

shèng	rén	zhě	yǒu	lì
勝	人	者	有	力
overcome	others	one-who	have	force

One who overcomes oneself is strong.

zì	shèng	zhě	qiáng
自	勝	者	強
self	overcome	one-who	strong

One who knows contentment is wealthy.

zhī	zú	zhě	fù
知	足	者	富
know	enough	one-who	wealthy

One who acts with determination has will.

qiáng	xíng	zhě	yǒu	zhì
強	行	者	有	志
forceful	act	one-who	have	will

One who loses not their position endures.

bù	shī	qí	suǒ	zhě	jiǔ
不	失	其	所	者	久
not	lose	their	place	one-who	endure

One who dies but does not perish has longevity.

sǐ	ér	bù	wáng	zhě	shòu
死	而	不	亡	者	壽
die	yet	not	perish	one-who	long-lived

Chapter 34

The great Dao flows everywhere.

dà	dào	fàn	xī
大	道	汎	兮
great	way	overflow	indeed

It can go left and right.

qí	kě	zuǒ	yòu
其	可	左	右
it	can	left	right

All things rely on it for life.

wàn	wù	shì	zhī	yǐ	shēng
萬	物	恃	之	以	生
ten-thousand	things	depend-on	it	by-means-of	live

Yet it does not refuse them.

ér	bù	cí
而	不	辭
yet	not	refuse

When work is accomplished, it succeeds.

gōng	chéng	sui
功	成	遂
achievement	complete	then

Yet it does not claim possession.

ér	bù	míng	yǒu
而	不	名	有
yet	not	name	possess

It clothes and nourishes all things.

yī	yǎng	wàn	wù
衣	養	萬	物
clothe	nourish	ten-thousand	things

Yet does not act as their master.

ér	bù	wéi	zhǔ
而	不	為	主
yet	not	act-as	master

Therefore it constantly lacks desires.

gù	cháng	wú	yù
故	常	無	欲
therefore	constant	without	desire

It can be named among the small.

kě	míng	yú	xiǎo
可	名	於	小
can	name	among	small

All things return to it.

wàn	wù	guī	yān
萬	物	歸	焉
ten-thousand	things	return	thereto

Yet it does not act as their master.

ér	bù	wéi	zhǔ
而	不	為	主
yet	not	act-as	master

It can be named among the great.

kě	míng	yú	dà
可	名	於	大
can	name	among	great

Thus the sage can achieve greatness.

shì yǐ shèng rén zhī néng chéng dà			
是	以	聖人之能	成大
thus-sage-can-achieve-great			

Because they do not make themselves great.

yǐ qí bù wéi dà			
以	其不為	大	
because-not-act-great			

Therefore they can achieve greatness.

gù	néng	chéng		dà
故	能	成	—	大
therefore	can	achieve		great

Chapter 35

Hold fast to the Great Image

zhí	dà	xiàng
執	大	象
grasp	great	image

All under heaven will come

tiān	xià	wǎng
天	下	往
heaven	below	go-toward

They come and are not harmed

wǎng	ér	bù	hài
往	而	不	害
go-toward	and	not	harm

Finding peace, equality, and greatness

ān	píng	tài
安	平	太
peaceful	level	great

Music and food cause passing travelers to stop

yuè	yǔ	ěr	guò	kè	zhǐ
樂	與	餌	過	客	止
music	and	food	pass	guest	stop

When the Dao is expressed in words, how bland it seems

dào	zhī	chū	yán	dàn	he
道	之	出	言	淡	呵
way	of	emerge	speak	bland	ah

How flavorless it is

qí	wú	wèi
其	無	味
its	without	flavor

Look at it, it cannot be seen enough

shì	zhī	bù	zú	jiàn
視	之	不	足	見
look	it	not	sufficient	see

Listen to it, it cannot be heard enough

tīng	zhī	bù	zú	wén
聽	之	不	足	聞
listen	it	not	sufficient	hear

Use it, it cannot be exhausted

yòng	zhī	bù	zú	jì
用	之	不	足	既
use	it	not	sufficient	exhaust

Chapter 36

If you wish to shrink something

jiāng	yù	shě	zhī
將	欲	歛	之
about-to	wish	contract	it

You must first allow it to expand

bì	gù	zhāng	zhī
必	固	張	之
must	indeed	expand	it

If you wish to weaken something

jiāng	yù	ruò	zhī
將	欲	弱	之
about-to	wish	weaken	it

You must first allow it to strengthen

bì	gù	qiáng	zhī
必	固	強	之
must	indeed	strengthen	it

If you wish to abandon something

jiāng	yù	fèi	zhī
將	欲	廢	之
about-to	wish	abandon	it

You must first allow it to flourish

bì	gù	xīng	zhī
必	固	興	之
must	indeed	flourish	it

If you wish to take something

jiāng	yù	duó	zhī
將	欲	奪	之
about-to	wish	take	it

You must first allow it to be given

bì	gù	yǔ	zhī
必	固	與	之
must	indeed	give	it

This is called subtle illumination

shì	wèi	wēi	míng
是	謂	微	明
this	called	subtle	bright

The soft and weak overcome the hard and strong

róu	ruò	shèng	gāng	qiáng
柔	弱	勝	剛	強
soft	weak	overcome	hard	strong

Fish cannot leave their deep waters

yú	bù	kě	tuō	yú	yuān
魚	不	可	脫	於	淵
fish	not	can	escape	from	deep-waters

The state's sharp weapons

guó	zhī	lì	qì
國	之	利	器
state	of	sharp	tools

Should not be displayed to others

bù	kě	yǐ	shì	rén
不	可	以	示	人
not	can	by-means-of	show	people

Chapter 37

The Dao constantly practices non-action.

dào	cháng	wú	wéi
道	常	無	為
way	constant	without	doing

Yet there is nothing it does not do.

ér	wú	bù	wéi
而	無	不	為
yet	without	not	doing

If lords and kings could maintain this,

hóu	wáng	ruò	néng	shǒu	zhī
侯	王	若	能	守	之
marquis	king	if	can	maintain	it

All things would transform naturally.

wàn	wù	jiāng	zì	huà
萬	物	將	自	化
ten-thousand	things	will	self	transform

When transformed, if desire should arise,

huà	ér	yù	zuò
化	而	欲	作
transform	and	desire	arise

I would stabilize them through the nameless uncarved block.

wú	jiāng	zhèn	zhī	yǐ	wú	míng	zhī
吾	將	鎮	之	以	無	名	之
I	will	stabilize	it	by-means-of	without	name	of
pǔ							
樸							
simplicity							

The nameless uncarved block

wú	míng	zhī	pǔ
無	名	之	樸
without	name	of	simplicity

Indeed, shall also be without desire.

fú	yì	jiāng	wú	yù
夫	亦	將	無	欲
indeed	also	will	without	desire

Through desirelessness comes stillness,

bù	yù	yǐ	jìng
不	欲	以	靜
not	desire	by-means-of	stillness

And the world will naturally settle into order.

tiān	xià	jiāng	zì	dìng
天	下	將	自	定
heaven	below	will	self	settle

Chapter 38

The highest virtue does not consider itself virtuous, thus it has virtue.

shàng	dé	bù	dé	shì	yǐ	yǒu	dé
上	德	不	德	是	以	有	德
highest	virtue	not	virtuous	this	therefore	have	virtue

Lower virtue does not lose virtue, thus it lacks virtue.

xià	dé	bù	shī	dé	shì	yǐ	wú	dé
下	德	不	失	德	是	以	無	德
lower	virtue	not	lose	virtue	this	therefore	without	virtue

The highest virtue acts without action and has no reason to act.

shàng	dé	wú	wéi	ér	wú	yǐ	wéi
上	德	無	為	而	無	以	為
highest	virtue	without	action	and	without	by-means-of	action

Lower virtue takes action and has reason to act.

xià	dé	wéi	zhī	ér	yǒu	yǐ	wéi
下	德	為	之	而	有	以	為
lower	virtue	acts	it	and	have	by-means-of	action

Highest benevolence acts and has no reason to act.

shàng	rén	wéi	zhī	ér	wú	yǐ	wéi
上	仁	為	之	而	無	以	為
highest	benevolence	acts	it	and	without	by-means-of	action

Highest righteousness acts and has reason to act.

shàng	yì	wéi	zhī	ér	yǒu	yǐ	wéi
上	義	為	之	而	有	以	為
highest	righteousness	acts	it	and	have	by-means-of	action

Highest ritual acts but none respond to it.

shàng	lǐ	wéi	zhī	ér	mò	zhī	yǐ	yīng
上	禮	為	之	而	莫	之	以	應
highest	ritual	acts	it	and	none	it	by-means-of	respond

Thus they roll up their sleeves and throw it at them.

zé	rǎng	bì	ér	réng	zhī
則	攘	臂	而	仍	之
then	roll-up	sleeve	and	still	it

Therefore, when the Way is lost, virtue appears.

gù	shī	dào	ér	hòu	dé
故	失	道	而	後	德
therefore	lose	way	and	after	virtue

When virtue is lost, benevolence appears.

shī	dé	ér	hòu	rén
失	德	而	後	仁
lose	virtue	and	after	benevolence

When benevolence is lost, righteousness appears.

shī	rén	ér	hòu	yì
失	仁	而	後	義
lose	benevolence	and	after	righteousness

When righteousness is lost, ritual appears.

shī	yì	ér	hòu	lǐ
失	義	而	後	禮
lose	righteousness	and	after	ritual

Now, ritual is the thinning of loyalty and trust.

fú	lǐ	zhě	zhōng	xìn	zhī	bó
夫	禮	者	忠	信	之	薄
now	ritual	is	loyalty	trust	of	thin

And the beginning of chaos.

ér	luàn	zhī	shǒu
而	亂	之	首
and	chaos	of	beginning

Foreknowledge is the flower of the Way.

qián	shí	zhě	dào	zhī	huá
前	識	者	道	之	華
fore	knowledge	is	way	of	flower

And the beginning of foolishness.

ér	yú	zhī	shǐ
而	愚	之	始
and	foolishness	of	beginning

Therefore the great person.

shì	yǐ	dà	zhàng	fū
是	以	大	丈	夫
this	therefore	great	person	man

Dwells in the substantial, not in the thin.

chǔ	qí	hòu	bù	jū	qí	bó
處	其	厚	不	居	其	薄
dwells	its	thick	not	reside	its	thin

Dwells in the fruit, not in the flower.

chǔ	qí	shí	bù	jū	qí	huá
處	其	實	不	居	其	華
dwells	its	fruit	not	reside	its	flower

Therefore rejects that and takes this.

gù	qù	bǐ	qǔ	cǐ
故	去	彼	取	此
therefore	reject	that	take	this

Chapter 39

Those who attained the One in ancient times:

xī	zhī	dé	yī	zhě
昔	之	得	一	者
ancient	of	attain	one	those-who

Heaven attained the One and became pure.

tiān	dé	yī	yī	qīng
天	得	一	以	清
heaven	attain	one	by-means-of	pure

Earth attained the One and became stable.

dì	dé	yī	yī	níng
地	得	一	以	寧
earth	attain	one	by-means-of	peaceful

Spirits attained the One and became powerful.

shén	dé	yī	yī	líng
神	得	一	以	靈
spirit	attain	one	by-means-of	efficacious

Valleys attained the One and became full.

gǔ	dé	yī	yī	yíng
谷	得	一	以	盈
valley	attain	one	by-means-of	full

Ten thousand things attained the One and came to life.

wàn	wù	dé	yī	yī	shēng
萬	物	得	一	以	生
ten-thousand	things	attain	one	by-means-of	live

Lords and kings attained the One and became righteous rulers of the world.

hóu	wáng	dé	yī	yī	wéi	tiān-xià	zhēn
侯	王	得	一	以	為	天下	貞
lord	king	attain	one	by-means-of	become	under-heaven	correct

This is what it leads to.

qí	zhì	zhī
其	致	之
its	result	it

Without that which makes it pure, Heaven would risk splitting apart.

tiān	wú	yī	qīng	jiāng	kǒng	liè
天	無	以	清	將	恐	裂
heaven	without	by-means-of	pure	would	fear	split

Without that which makes it stable, Earth would risk bursting open.

dì	wú	yī	níng	jiāng	kǒng	fā
地	無	以	寧	將	恐	發
earth	without	by-means-of	peaceful	would	fear	burst

Without that which makes them powerful, spirits would risk fading away.

shén	wú	yǐ	líng	jiāng	kǒng	xiē
神	無	以	靈	將	恐	歇
spirit	without	by-means-of	efficacious	would	fear	cease

Without that which makes them full, valleys would risk drying up.

gǔ	wú	yǐ	yíng	jiāng	kǒng	jié
谷	無	以	盈	將	恐	竭
valley	without	by-means-of	full	would	fear	exhaust

Without that which gives them life, the ten thousand things would risk extinction.

wàn	wù	wú	yǐ	shēng	jiāng	kǒng	miè
萬	物	無	以	生	將	恐	滅
ten-thousand	things	without	by-means-of	live	would	fear	extinguish

Without that which makes them noble and high, lords and kings would risk falling.

hóu	wáng	wú	yǐ	guì	gāo	jiāng	kǒng	jué
侯	王	無	以	貴	高	將	恐	蹶
lord	king	without	by-means-of	noble	high	would	fear	stumble

Therefore, the noble takes the humble as its root.

gù	guì	yǐ	jiàn	wéi	běn
故	貴	以	賤	為	本
therefore	noble	by-means-of	humble	make	root

The high takes the low as its foundation.

gāo	yǐ	xià	wéi	jī
高	以	下	為	基
high	by-means-of	low	make	foundation

Thus lords and kings call themselves 'orphaned,' 'widowed,' and 'unworthy.'

shì	yǐ	hóu	wáng	zì	wèi	gū	guǎ
是	以	侯	王	自	謂	孤	寡
this	by-means-of	lord	king	self	call	orphaned	widowed

bù	gǔ
不	穀
not	worthy

Is this not taking the humble as root?

cǐ	fēi	yǐ	jiàn	wéi	běn	yé
此	非	以	賤	為	本	邪
this	not	by-means-of	humble	make	root	is-it-not

Is it not so?

fēi	hū
非	乎
not	question

Therefore, the highest honor is no honor.

gù	zhì	shù	yú	wú	yú
故	致	數	輿	無	輿
therefore	ultimate	count	carriage	no	carriage

Do not desire to shine like jade,

bù	yù	lù	lù	rú	yù
不	欲	瑤	瑤	如	玉
not	desire	glossy	glossy	like	jade

But be as ordinary as stone.

luò	luò	rú	shí
珞	珞	如	石
plain	plain	like	stone

Chapter 40

Reversal is the movement of the Way.

fǎn	zhě	dào	zhī	dòng
反	者	道	之	動
return	that-which	way	of	movement

Weakness is the function of the Way.

ruò	zhě	dào	zhī	yòng
弱	者	道	之	用
weak	that-which	way	of	function

The ten thousand things under heaven are born from being.

tiān	xià	wàn	wù	shēng	yú	yǒu
天	下	萬	物	生	於	有
heaven	below	ten-thousand	things	born	from	being

Being is born from non-being.

yǒu	shēng	yú	wú
有	生	於	無
being	born	from	non-being

Chapter 41

When a superior scholar hears of the Dao, they diligently practice it.

shàng	shì	wén	dào	qín	ér	xíng	zhī
上	士	聞	道	勤	而	行	之
upper	scholar	hear	way	diligent	and	practice	it

When a middling scholar hears of the Dao, it seems sometimes present, sometimes absent.

zhōng	shì	wén	dào	ruò	cún	ruò	wáng
中	士	聞	道	若	存	若	亡
middle	scholar	hear	way	as-if	exist	as-if	gone

When a lesser scholar hears of the Dao, they laugh greatly at it.

xià	shì	wén	dào	dà	xiào	zhī
下	士	聞	道	大	笑	之
lower	scholar	hear	way	great	laugh	it

If it were not laughed at, it would not be sufficient to be the Dao.

bù	xiào	bù	zú	yǐ	wéi	dào
不	笑	不	足	以	為	道
not	laugh	not	sufficient	by-means-of	become	way

Therefore the established sayings declare:

gù	jiàn	yán	yǒu	zhī	yuē
故	建	言	有	之	曰
therefore	establish	words	have	it	say

The bright way seems dim.

míng	dào	ruò	mèi
明	道	若	昧
bright	way	as-if	dim

The advancing way seems retreating.

jìn	dào	ruò	tuì
進	道	若	退
advance	way	as-if	retreat

The smooth way seems rough.

yí	dào	ruò	lěi
夷	道	若	類
smooth	way	as-if	rough

The highest virtue is like a valley.

shàng	dé	ruò	gǔ
上	德	若	谷
highest	virtue	as-if	valley

Great whiteness seems soiled.

dà	bái	ruò	rǔ
大	白	若	辱
great	white	as-if	shame

Broad virtue seems insufficient.

guǎng	dé	ruò	bù	zú
廣	德	若	不	足
broad	virtue	as-if	not	sufficient

Established virtue seems stolen.

jiàn	dé	ruò	tōu
建	德	若	偷
establish	virtue	as-if	steal

True substance seems to change.

zhì	zhēn	ruò	yǔ
質	真	若	渝
substance	true	as-if	change

The great square has no corners.

dà	fāng	wú	yú
大	方	無	隅
great	square	without	corner

The great vessel is late in completion.

dà	qì	wǎn	chéng
大	器	晚	成
great	vessel	late	complete

The great sound is rarified in voice.

dà	yīn	xī	shēng
大	音	希	聲
great	sound	rare	voice

The great image has no form.

dà	xiàng	wú	xíng
大	象	無	形
great	image	without	form

The Dao is hidden and nameless.

dào	yīn	wú	míng
道	隱	無	名
way	hidden	without	name

Yet it is the Dao alone that excels in giving and in completion.

fú	wéi	dào	shàn	shǐ	qiè	shàn	chéng
夫	唯	道	善	始	且	善	成
indeed	only	way	good-at	beginning	and	good-at	complete

Chapter 42

The Dao gives birth to One

dào	shēng	yī
道	生	一
way	generate	one

One gives birth to Two

yī	shēng	èr
一	生	二
one	generate	two

Two gives birth to Three

èr	shēng	sān
二	生	三
two	generate	three

Three gives birth to the ten thousand things

sān	shēng	wàn	wù
三	生	萬	物
three	generate	ten-thousand	things

The ten thousand things carry yin and embrace yang

wàn	wù	fù	yīn	ér	bào	yáng
萬	物	負	陰	而	抱	陽
ten-thousand	things	carry	yin	and	embrace	yang

Through vital energy they achieve harmony

chōng	qì	yǐ	wéi	hé
冲	氣	以	為	和
vital	energy	by-means-of	become	harmony

What people detest

rén	zhī	suǒ	wù
人	之	所	惡
people	of	that-which	detest

Is being orphaned, widowed, and resourceless

wéi	gū	guǎ	bù	gǔ
唯	孤	寡	不	穀
only	orphaned	widowed	not	grain

Yet kings and dukes use these as their titles

ér	wáng	gōng	yǐ	zì	chéng
而	王	公	以	自	稱
yet	king	duke	by-means-of	self	call

Therefore, things

gù	wù
故	物
therefore	things

Sometimes through loss there is gain

huò	sǔn	zhī	ér	yì
或	損	之	而	益
perhaps	decrease	it	yet	increase

Sometimes through gain there is loss

huò	yì	zhī	ér	sǔn
或	益	之	而	損
perhaps	increase	it	yet	decrease

What others teach, I also teach

rén	zhī	suǒ	jiào	wǒ	yì	jiāo	zhī
人	之	所	教	我	亦	教	之
people	of	that-which	teach	I	also	teach	it

The forceful and unyielding do not meet their natural end

qiáng	liáng	zhě	bù	dé	qí	sǐ
強	梁	者	不	得	其	死
strong	unyielding	one-who	not	obtain	their	death

I will take this as the father of my teaching

wú	jiāng	yǐ	wéi	jiāo	fù
吾	將	以	為	教	父
I	will	by-means-of	make	teaching	father

Chapter 43

The softest thing in the universe

tiān	xià	zhī	zhì	róu
天	下	之	至	柔
heaven	below	of	most	soft

Races through the hardest thing in the universe

chí	chéng	tiān	xià	zhī	zhì	jiān
馳	騁	天	下	之	至	堅
gallop	speed	heaven	below	of	most	hard

That which has no substance enters where there is no space

wú	yǒu	rù	wú	jiān
無	有	入	無	間
not-have	have	enter	not-have	space

Through this I know the benefit of non-action

wú	shì	yǐ	zhī	wú	wéi	zhī	yǒu	yì
吾	是	以	知	無	為	之	有	益
I	this	by-means-of	know	not-have	do	of	have	benefit

The teaching without words

bù	yán	zhī	jiào
不	言	之	教
not	speak	of	teach

The benefit of non-action

wú	wéi	zhī	yì
無	為	之	益
not-have	do	of	benefit

Few in the world can attain this

tiān	xià	xī	jí	zhī
天	下	希	及	之
heaven	below	rare	reach	it

Chapter 44

Between name and self, which is closer?

míng	yǔ	shēn	shú	qīn
名	與	身	孰	親
name	and	self	which	close

Between self and wealth, which is more?

shēn	yǔ	huò	shú	duō
身	與	貨	孰	多
self	and	goods	which	more

Between gain and loss, which brings more pain?

dé	yǔ	wáng	shú	bìng
得	與	亡	孰	病
gain	and	lose	which	illness

Excessive love must lead to great cost.

shèn	ài	bì	dà	fèi
甚	愛	必	大	費
excessive	love	must	great	cost

Much hoarding must lead to heavy loss.

duō	cáng	bì	hòu	wáng
多	藏	必	厚	亡
much	store	must	heavy	lose

Knowing contentment avoids shame.

zhī	zú	bù	rǔ
知	足	不	辱
know	enough	not	shame

Knowing when to stop avoids danger.

zhī	zhǐ	bù	dài
知	止	不	殆
know	stop	not	danger

Thus can one endure long.

kě	yǐ	cháng	jiǔ
可	以	長	久
can	by-means-of	long	lasting

Chapter 45

Great perfection seems incomplete.

dà	chéng	ruò	quē
大	成	若	缺
great	completion	like	lacking

Yet its use is inexhaustible.

qí	yòng	bù	bì
其	用	不	弊
its	use	not	worn-out

Great fullness seems empty.

dà	yíng	ruò	zhōng
大	盈	若	盅
great	fullness	like	empty

Yet its use is endless.

qí	yòng	bù	qióng
其	用	不	窮
its	use	not	exhausted

Great straightness seems bent.

dà	zhí	ruò	qū
大	直	若	屈
great	straight	like	bent

Great skill seems awkward.

dà	qiǎo	ruò	zhuō
大	巧	若	拙
great	skilled	like	clumsy

Great eloquence seems stuttering.

dà	biàn	ruò	nè
大	辯	若	訥
great	eloquence	like	stuttering

Movement overcomes cold.

zào	shèng	hán
躁	勝	寒
movement	overcomes	cold

Stillness overcomes heat.

jìng	shèng	rè
靜	勝	熱
stillness	overcomes	heat

Pure tranquility becomes the way of heaven.

qīng	jìng	wéi	tiān	xià	zhèng
清	靜	為	天	下	正
pure	still	becomes	heaven	below	proper

Chapter 46

When the Way prevails in the world,

tiān	xià	yǒu	dào
天	下	有	道
heaven	below	have	way

Retiring horses are used for fertilizing fields.

què	zǒu	mǎ	yǐ	fèn
卻	走	馬	以	糞
retire	running	horse	by-means-of	manure

When the Way is absent from the world,

tiān	xià	wú	dào
天	下	無	道
heaven	below	not-have	way

War horses breed in the suburbs.

róng	mǎ	shēng	yú	jiāo
戎	馬	生	於	郊
war	horse	born	at	outskirts

No crime is greater than yielding to desire.

zuì	mò	dà	yú	kě	yù
罪	莫	大	於	可	欲
crime	none	greater	than	permissible	desire

No disaster is greater than not knowing contentment.

huò	mò	dà	yú	bù	zhī	zú
禍	莫	大	於	不	知	足
disaster	none	greater	than	not	know	enough

No fault is greater than wanting to acquire more.

jiù	mò	dà	yú	yù	dé
咎	莫	大	於	欲	得
fault	none	greater	than	desire	obtain

Therefore, knowing contentment's contentment is eternal contentment.

gù	zhī	zú	zhī	zú	cháng	zú	yī
故	知	足	之	足	常	足	矣
therefore	know	enough	of	enough	constant	enough	indeed

Chapter 47

Without going beyond one's door

bù	chū	hù
不	出	戶
not	go-out	door

One can know the world

yǐ	zhī	tiān	xià
以	知	天	下
by-means-of	know	heaven	below

Without peering through one's window

bù	kuī	yǒu
不	闚	牖
not	peek	window

One can know the Way of Heaven

yǐ	zhī	tiān	dào
以	知	天	道
by-means-of	know	heaven	way

The further one goes

qí	chū	mí	yuǎn
其	出	彌	遠
its	go-out	increasingly	far

The less one knows

qí	zhī	mí	shǎo
其	知	彌	少
its	know	increasingly	little

Therefore the sage

shì	yǐ	shèng	rén
是	以	聖	人
this	by-means-of	sage	person

Without moving, yet knows

bù	xíng	ér	zhī
不	行	而	知
not	walk	yet	know

Without seeing, yet names

bù	jiàn	ér	míng
不	見	而	名
not	see	yet	name

Without acting, yet accomplishes

bù	wéi	ér	chéng
不	為	而	成
not	do	yet	complete

Chapter 48

Those who pursue learning gain more each day.

wéi	xué	zhě	rì	yì
為	學	者	日	益
engage-in	learning	one-who	day	increase

Those who pursue the Dao reduce more each day.

wéi	dào	zhě	rì	sǔn
為	道	者	日	損
engage-in	dao	one-who	day	decrease

Reduce and reduce again.

sǔn	zhī	yòu	sǔn
損	之	又	損
decrease	it	again	decrease

Until one reaches non-action.

yǐ	zhì	yú	wú	wéi
以	至	於	無	為
by-means-of	arrive	at	non	action

Through non-action, nothing is left undone.

wú	wéi	ér	wú	bù	wéi
無	為	而	無	不	為
non	action	yet	nothing	not	do

The world is gained by constant non-interference.

qǔ	tiān	xià	cháng	yǐ	wú	shì
取	天	下	常	以	無	事
take	heaven	below	always	by-means-of	non	affairs

As soon as there is interference,

jí	qí	yǒu	shì
及	其	有	事
when	it	have	affairs

One becomes inadequate to gain the world.

bù	zú	yǐ	qǔ	tiān	xià
不	足	以	取	天	下
not	sufficient	by-means-of	take	heaven	below

Chapter 49

The sage has no fixed mind-heart

shèng	rén	wú	cháng	xīn
聖	人	無	常	心
sage	person	without	constant	heart

Takes the heart-mind of the common people as their own heart-mind

yǐ	bǎi	xìng	xīn	wéi	xīn
以	百	姓	心	為	心
by-means-of	hundred	surnames	heart	make	heart

To those who are good, I am good to them

shàn	zhě	wú	shàn	zhī
善	者	吾	善	之
good	those	I	good	them

To those who are not good, I am also good to them

bù	shàn	zhě	wú	yì	shàn	zhī
不	善	者	吾	亦	善	之
not	good	those	I	also	good	them

This is the virtue of goodness

dé	shàn
德	善
virtue	good

To those who are trustworthy, I trust them

xìn	zhě	wú	xìn	zhī
信	者	吾	信	之
trust	those	I	trust	them

To those who are not trustworthy, I also trust them

bù	xìn	zhě	wú	yì	xìn	zhī
不	信	者	吾	亦	信	之
not	trust	those	I	also	trust	them

This is the virtue of trust

dé	xìn
德	信
virtue	trust

The sage dwells under heaven carefully and attentively

shèng	rén	zài	tiān	xià	xī	xī
聖	人	在	天	下	歛	歛
sage	person	at	heaven	below	careful	careful

For this reason merges their heart-mind with all under heaven

yān	wéi	tiān	xià	hún	qí	xīn
焉	為	天	下	渾	其	心
therefore	for	heaven	below	merge	their	heart

The common people all focus their ears and eyes

bǎi	xìng	jiē	zhù	qí	ěr	mù
百	姓	皆	注	其	耳	目
hundred	surnames	all	focus	their	ears	eyes

The sage treats them all as children

shèng	rén	jiē	hái	zhī
聖	人	皆	孩	之
sage	person	all	child	them

Chapter 50

Emerging into life, entering into death.

chū	shēng	rù	sǐ
出	生	入	死
emerge	life	enter	death

The followers of life are thirteen.

shēng	zhī	tú	shí	yǒu	sān
生	之	徒	十	有	三
life	of	followers	ten	have	three

The followers of death are thirteen.

sǐ	zhī	tú	shí	yǒu	sān
死	之	徒	十	有	三
death	of	followers	ten	have	three

In human life, the places of movement leading to death-ground are also thirteen.

rén	zhī	shēng	dòng	zhī	sǐ	dì
人	之	生	動	之	死	地
human	of	life	movement	of	death	ground

Also thirteen.

yì	shí	yǒu	sān
亦	十	有	三
also	ten	have	three

Now, why is this so?

fú	hé	gù
夫	何	故
now	what	reason

Because of the intensity with which they live life.

yǐ	qí	shēng	shēng	zhī	hòu
以	其	生	生	之	厚
by-means-of	their	live	life	of	thick

Indeed, I have heard that one who is good at nurturing life

gài	wén	shàn	shè	shēng	zhě
蓋	聞	善	攝	生	者
indeed	hear	good-at	nurture	life	one-who

Traveling on land, meets neither rhinoceros nor tiger.

líng	xíng	bù	yù	sì	hǔ
陵	行	不	遇	兕	虎
land	travel	not	meet	rhinoceros	tiger

Entering battle, needs no armor or weapons.

rù	jūn	bù	bèi	jiǎ	bīng
入	軍	不	被	甲	兵
enter	army	not	wear	armor	weapon

The rhinoceros finds nowhere to thrust its horn.

sì	wú	suǒ	tóu	qí	jiǎo
兕	無	所	投	其	角
rhinoceros	no	place	thrust	its	horn

The tiger finds nowhere to place its claws.

hǔ	wú	suǒ	cuò	qí	zhǎo
虎	無	所	措	其	爪
tiger	no	place	put	its	claw

Weapons find nowhere to lodge their blades.

bīng	wú	suǒ	róng	qí	rèn
兵	無	所	容	其	刃
weapon	no	place	contain	its	blade

Now, why is this so?

fú	hé	gù
夫	何	故
now	what	reason

Because in them there is no death-ground.

yǐ	qí	wú	sǐ	dì
以	其	無	死	地
by-means-of	their	no	death	ground

Chapter 51

The Dao gives birth to them

dào	shēng	zhī
道	生	之
way	give-birth	them

Virtue nurtures them

dé	xù	zhī
德	畜	之
virtue	nurture	them

Matter shapes them

wù	xíng	zhī
物	形	之
matter	shape	them

Circumstances complete them

shì	chéng	zhī
勢	成	之
circumstances	complete	them

Therefore among all things

shì	yǐ	wàn	wù
是	以	萬	物
this	by-means-of	ten-thousand	things

None fail to revere the Dao and honor virtue

mò	bù	zūn	dào	ér	guì	dé
莫	不	尊	道	而	貴	德
none	not	revere	way	and	value	virtue

The Dao's reverence

dào	zhī	zūn
道	之	尊
way	of	revere

Virtue's value

dé	zhī	guì
德	之	貴
virtue	of	value

Indeed none commands them

fú	mò	zhī	mìng
夫	莫	之	命
indeed	none	them	command

Yet they are naturally so

ér	cháng	zì	rán
而	常	自	然
yet	always	self	so

Thus the Dao gives birth and virtue nurtures

gù	dào	shēng	zhī	dé	xù	zhī
故	道	生	之	德	畜	之
therefore	way	give-birth	them	virtue	nurture	them

Grows them and develops them

zhǎng	zhī	yù	zhī
長	之	育	之
grow	them	rear	them

Stabilizes them and matures them

tíng	zhī	dú	zhī
亭	之	毒	之
stabilize	them	mature	them

Nourishes them and protects them

yǎng	zhī	fù	zhī
養	之	覆	之
nourish	them	protect	them

Gives life without possessing

shēng	ér	bù	yǒu
生	而	不	有
give-birth	yet	not	possess

Acts without depending

wéi	ér	bù	shì
為	而	不	恃
do	yet	not	rely-on

Leads without controlling

zhǎng	ér	bù	zài
長	而	不	宰
grow	yet	not	control

This is called profound virtue

shì	wèi	xuán	dé
是	謂	玄	德
this	called	profound	virtue

Chapter 52

The world has a beginning

tiān	xià	yǒu	shǐ
天	下	有	始
heaven	below	has	beginning

Which is regarded as the mother of all things

yǐ	wéi	tiān	xià	mǔ
以	為	天	下	母
by-means-of	become	heaven	below	mother

Having found the mother

jì	dé	qí	mǔ
既	得	其	母
already	obtain	its	mother

Through this know the child

yǐ	zhī	qí	zǐ
以	知	其	子
by-means-of	know	its	child

Having known the child

jì	zhī	qí	zǐ
既	知	其	子
already	know	its	child

Return to guard the mother

fù	shǒu	qí	mǔ
復	守	其	母
return	guard	its	mother

To the end of life, there will be no danger

mò	shēn	bù	dài
沒	身	不	殆
end	body	not	dangerous

Block the passages, shut the doors

sè	qí	duì	bì	qí	mén
塞	其	兌	閉	其	門
block	its	opening	close	its	door

To the end of life, there will be no toil

zhōng	shēn	bù	qín
終	身	不	勤
end	body	not	toil

Open the passages, attend to affairs

kāi	qí	duì	jì	qí	shì
開	其	兌	濟	其	事
open	its	opening	manage	its	affairs

To the end of life, there will be no salvation

zhōng	shēn	bù	jiù
終	身	不	救
end	body	not	save

Seeing the small is called enlightenment

jiàn	xiǎo	yuē	míng
見	小	曰	明
see	small	called	bright

Keeping to gentleness is called strength

shǒu	róu	yuē	qiáng
守	柔	曰	強
guard	soft	called	strong

Use the light, return again to brightness

yòng	qí	guāng	fù	guī	qí	míng
用	其	光	復	歸	其	明
use	its	light	return	return-to	its	brightness

Leave no misfortune upon the body

wú	yí	shēn	yǎng
無	遺	身	殃
not	leave	body	disaster

This is called practicing the constant

shì	wèi	xí	cháng
是	謂	習	常
this	called	practice	constant

Chapter 53

Let me have just a little knowledge.

shǐ	wǒ	jiè	rán	yǒu	zhī
使	我	介	然	有	知
let	I	small	thus	have	knowledge

Walking on the great Way.

xíng	yú	dà	dào
行	於	大	道
walk	upon	great	way

Only the deviation is fearsome.

wéi	yí	shì	wèi
唯	迤	是	畏
only	deviate	this	fear

The great Way is very level.

dà	dào	shèn	yí
大	道	甚	夷
great	way	very	level

Yet people prefer shortcuts.

ér	mín	hǎo	jīng
而	民	好	徑
yet	people	prefer	shortcut

The court is very splendid.

cháo	shèn	chú
朝	甚	除
court	very	clear

The fields are very weedy.

tián	shèn	wú
田	甚	蕪
field	very	overgrown

The granaries are very empty.

cāng	shèn	xū
倉	甚	虛
granary	very	empty

Wearing ornate clothing.

fú	wéncǎi
服	文綵
wear	ornate-clothes

Carrying sharp swords.

dài	lì	jiàn
帶	利	劍
carry	sharp	sword

Gorged with food and drink.

yàn	yīn	shí
厭	飲	食
satiated	drink	food

Wealth and goods in excess.

cái	huò	yǒu	yú
財	貨	有	餘
wealth	goods	have	excess

This is called robber-boasting.

shì	wèi	dào	kuā
是	謂	盜	夸
this	called	robber	boast

Truly not the Way!

fēi	dào	yě	zāi
非	道	也	哉
not	way	indeed	emphasis

Chapter 54

What is well established will not be uprooted.

shàn	jiàn	zhě	bù	bá
善	建	者	不	拔
good-at	establish	one-who	not	uproot

What is well embraced will not slip away.

shàn	bào	zhě	bù	tuō
善	抱	者	不	脫
good-at	embrace	one-who	not	slip-away

Descendants will continue their ancestral sacrifices without cessation.

zǐ	sūn	yǐ	jì	sì	bù	chuò
子	孫	以	祭	祀	不	輟
child	grandchild	by-means-of	sacrifice	worship	not	cease

Cultivate it in your person, and the virtue becomes genuine.

xiū	zhī	—	shēn	qí	dé	nǎi	zhēn
修	之	—	身	其	德	乃	真
cultivate	it		person	its	virtue	then	true

Cultivate it in the family, and the virtue becomes abundant.

xiū	zhī	—	jiā	qí	dé	nǎi	yú
修	之	—	家	其	德	乃	餘
cultivate	it		family	its	virtue	then	abundant

Cultivate it in the village, and the virtue becomes lasting.

xiū	zhī		xiāng	qí	dé	nǎi	cháng
修	之	—	鄉	其	德	乃	長
cultivate	it		village	its	virtue	then	long-lasting

Cultivate it in the state, and the virtue becomes prosperous.

xiū	zhī		guó	qí	dé	nǎi	fēng
修	之	—	國	其	德	乃	豐
cultivate	it		state	its	virtue	then	prosperous

Cultivate it in the world, and the virtue becomes universal.

xiū	zhī		tiān	xià	qí	dé	nǎi	pǔ
修	之	—	天	下	其	德	乃	普
cultivate	it		heaven	below	its	virtue	then	universal

Therefore, observe the person through the person.

gù	yǐ	shēn	guān	shēn
故	以	身	觀	身
therefore	by-means-of	person	observe	person

Observe the family through the family.

yǐ	jiā	guān	jiā
以	家	觀	家
by-means-of	family	observe	family

Observe the village through the village.

yǐ	xiāng	guān	xiāng
以	鄉	觀	鄉
by-means-of	village	observe	village

Observe the state through the state.

yǐ	guó	guān	guó
以	國	觀	國
by-means-of	state	observe	state

Observe the world through the world.

yǐ	tiān	xià	guān	tiān	xià
以	天	下	觀	天	下
by-means-of	heaven	below	observe	heaven	below

How do I know the world is thus?

wú	hé	yǐ	zhī	tiān	xià	rán	zāi
吾	何	以	知	天	下	然	哉
I	how	by-means-of	know	heaven	below	thus	indeed

Through this.

yǐ	cǐ
以	此
by-means-of	this

Chapter 55

One who possesses profound virtue

hán	dé	zhī	hòu	zhě
含	德	之	厚	者
contain	virtue	of	thick	one-who

Is comparable to a newborn child

bǐ	yú	chì	zǐ
比	於	赤	子
compare	to	red	child

Wasps, scorpions, vipers, and snakes do not sting it

fēng	chài	huī	shé	bù	shì
蜂	蠆	虺	蛇	不	螫
wasp	scorpion	viper	snake	not	sting

Fierce beasts do not seize it

měng	shòu	bù	jù
猛	獸	不	據
fierce	beast	not	seize

Birds of prey do not strike it

jué	niǎo	bù	tuán
攫	鳥	不	搏
predatory	bird	not	strike

Bones weak, sinews soft, yet its grip is firm

gǔ	ruò	jīn	róu	ér	wò	gù
骨	弱	筋	柔	而	握	固
bone	weak	sinew	soft	yet	grip	firm

Not yet knowing the union of male and female, yet its vitality manifests

wèi	zhī	pīn	mù	zhī	hé	ér	xuān	zuò
未	知	牝	牡	之	合	而	腴	作
not-yet	know	female	male	of	union	yet	vital-force	arise

This is the perfection of essence

jīng	zhī	zhì	yě
精	之	至	也
essence	of	ultimate	indeed

Crying all day without becoming hoarse

zhōng	rì	háo	ér	bù	shà
終	日	號	而	不	嗄
whole	day	cry	yet	not	hoarse

This is the perfection of harmony

hé	zhī	zhì	yě
和	之	至	也
harmony	of	ultimate	indeed

To know harmony is called constancy

zhī	hé	yuē	cháng
知	和	曰	常
know	harmony	called	constant

To know constancy is called enlightenment

zhī	cháng	yuē	míng
知	常	曰	明
know	constant	called	bright

Enriching life is called fortune

yì	shēng	yuē	xiáng
益	生	曰	祥
benefit	life	called	fortune

Mind controlling breath is called force

xīn	shǐ	qì	yuē	qiáng
心	使	氣	曰	強
heart-mind	control	breath	called	strong

When things mature they become old

wù	zhuàng	zé	lǎo
物	壯	則	老
thing	strong	then	old

This is called not following the Way

wèi	zhī	bù	dào
謂	之	不	道
called	it	not	way

Not following the Way leads to early death

bù	dào	zǎo	yǐ
不	道	早	已
not	way	early	end

Chapter 56

Those who know do not speak.

zhī	zhě	bù	yán
知	者	不	言
know	one-who	not	speak

Those who speak do not know.

yán	zhě	bù	zhī
言	者	不	知
speak	one-who	not	know

Block the openings, shut the gates.

sāi	qí	duì	bì	qí	mén
塞	其	兌	閉	其	門
block	its	opening	close	its	gate

Blunt the sharpness.

cuò	qí	ruì
挫	其	銳
blunt	its	sharp

Untangle the knots.

jiě	qí	fēn
解	其	紛
untie	its	tangled

Soften the glare.

hé	qí	guāng
和	其	光
harmonize	its	light

Merge with the dust.

tóng	qí	chén
同	其	塵
unite	its	dust

This is called mysterious unity.

shì	wèi	xuán	tóng
是	謂	玄	同
this	called	mysterious	unity

Therefore one cannot get close to it.

gù	bù	kě	dé	ér	qīn
故	不	可	得	而	親
therefore	not	can	obtain	and	intimate

One cannot keep it at a distance.

bù	kě	dé	ér	shū
不	可	得	而	疏
not	can	obtain	and	distant

One cannot benefit from it.

bù	kě	dé	ér	lì
不	可	得	而	利
not	can	obtain	and	benefit

One cannot harm it.

bù	kě	dé	ér	hài
不	可	得	而	害
not	can	obtain	and	harm

One cannot honor it.

bù	kě	dé	ér	guì
不	可	得	而	貴
not	can	obtain	and	value

One cannot debase it.

bù	kě	dé	ér	jiàn
不	可	得	而	賤
not	can	obtain	and	despise

Therefore it is valued by all under heaven.

gù	wéi	tiān	xià	guì
故	為	天	下	貴
therefore	become	heaven	under	valued

Chapter 57

By means of the correct/orthodox way to govern the country

yǐ	zhèng	zhì	guó
以	正	治	國
by-means-of	correct	govern	country

By means of the unorthodox to deploy troops

yǐ	qí	yòng	bīng
以	奇	用	兵
by-means-of	unusual	use	troops

By means of non-action to gain the world

yǐ	wú	shì	qǔ	tiān	xià
以	無	事	取	天	下
by-means-of	without	affairs	take	heaven	below

How do I know it is so?

wú	hé	yǐ	zhī	qí	rán	zāi
吾	何	以	知	其	然	哉
I	how	by-means-of	know	its	so	indeed

Through this:

yǐ	cǐ
以	此
by-means-of	this

When the world has many prohibitions

tiān	xià	duō	jì	huì
天	下	多	忌	諱
heaven	below	many	taboo	avoid

The people become increasingly poor

ér	mín	mí	pín
而	民	彌	貧
yet	people	increasingly	poor

When people have many sharp weapons

mín	duō	lì	qì
民	多	利	器
people	many	sharp	tools

The state grows increasingly confused

guó	jiā	zī	hūn	
而	國	家	滋	昏
yet	country	family	grow	confused

When people have much knowledge and skill

rén	duō	zhī	qiǎo
人	多	知	巧
people	many	knowledge	skill

Strange things increasingly arise

	qí	wù	zī	qǐ
而	奇	物	滋	起
yet	strange	things	grow	arise

As laws and regulations multiply

fǎ		zī	
法	物	滋	章
law	things	grow	manifest

Thieves and robbers become more numerous

dào	zéi	duō	yǒu
盜	賊	多	有
thief	robber	many	exist

Therefore the sage says

	shèng	rén	yún
故	聖	人	云
therefore	sage	person	say

I practice non-action and the people transform themselves

wǒ	wú	wéi	ér	mín	zì	huà
我	無	為	而	民	自	化
I	without	action	yet	people	self	transform

I love quietude and the people rectify themselves

wǒ	hào	jìng	ér	mín	zì	zhèng
我	好	靜	而	民	自	正
I	love	quiet	yet	people	self	correct

I take no action and the people prosper by themselves

wǒ	wú	shì	ér	mín	zì	fù
我	無	事	而	民	自	富
I	without	affairs	yet	people	self	wealthy

I have no desires and the people become simple by themselves

wǒ	wú	yù	ér	mín	zì	pǔ
我	無	欲	而	民	自	樸
I	without	desire	yet	people	self	simple

Chapter 58

Their governance is dull and inactive.

qí	zhèng	mèn	mèn
其	政	悶	悶
their	governance	dull	dull

Their people are simple and honest.

qí	mín	chún	chún
其	民	淳	淳
their	people	pure	pure

Their governance is scrutinizing and strict.

qí	zhèng	chá	chá
其	政	察	察
their	governance	examine	examine

Their people are deficient and wanting.

qí	mín	quē	quē
其	民	缺	缺
their	people	lacking	lacking

Misfortune! It is what fortune leans upon.

huò	xī	fú	zhī	suǒ	yī
禍	兮	福	之	所	倚
misfortune	ah	fortune	of	that-which	lean-on

Fortune! It is where misfortune hides.

fú	xī	huò	zhī	suǒ	fú
福	兮	禍	之	所	伏
fortune	ah	misfortune	of	that-which	hide

Who knows their limits?

shú	zhī	qí	jí
孰	知	其	極
who	know	their	limit

There is no fixed standard.

qí	wú	zhèng
其	無	正
its	not-have	proper

The proper returns to become the strange.

zhèng	fù	wéi	qí
正	復	為	奇
proper	return	become	strange

The good returns to become the ominous.

shàn	fù	wéi	yāo
善	復	為	妖
good	return	become	evil

People's delusion!

rén	zhī	mí
人	之	迷
people	of	delusion

Its days have indeed been long.

qí	rì	gù	jiǔ
其	日	固	久
its	days	indeed	long

Therefore the sage is:

shì	yǐ	shèng	rén
是	以	聖	人
this	by-means-of	sage	person

Square but does not cut.

fāng	ér	bù	gē
方	而	不	割
square	yet	not	cut

Sharp but does not pierce.

lián	ér	bù	guī
廉	而	不	刺
sharp	yet	not	pierce

Straight but does not extend too far.

zhí	ér	bù	sì
直	而	不	肆
straight	yet	not	unbridled

Bright but does not dazzle.

guāng	ér	bù	yào
光	而	不	耀
bright	yet	not	dazzle

Chapter 59

In governing people and serving heaven

zhì	rén	shì	tiān
治	人	事	天
govern	people	serve	heaven

Nothing compares to frugality

mò	ruò	sè
莫	若	嗇
nothing	like	frugal

For only through frugality

fū	wéi	sè
夫	唯	嗇
indeed	only	frugal

This is called early submission

shì	wèi	zǎo	fú
是	謂	早	服
this	called	early	submit

Early submission means repeatedly accumulating virtue

zǎo	fú	wèi	zhī	chóng	jī	dé
早	服	謂	之	重	積	德
early	submit	called	it	repeatedly	accumulate	virtue

Repeatedly accumulating virtue

chóng	jī	dé
重	積	德
repeatedly	accumulate	virtue

Then there is nothing that cannot be overcome

zé	wú	bù	kè
則	無	不	克
then	nothing	not	overcome

When there is nothing that cannot be overcome

wú	bù	kè
無	不	克
nothing	not	overcome

Then no one knows one's limits

zé	mò	zhī	qí	jí
則	莫	知	其	極
then	none	know	its	limit

When no one knows one's limits

mò	zhī	qí	jí
莫	知	其	極
none	know	its	limit

One can possess the state

kě	yǐ	yǒu	guó
可	以	有	國
can	by-means-of	have	state

Possessing the mother of the state

yǒu	guó	zhī	mǔ
有	國	之	母
have	state	of	mother

One can long endure

kě	yǐ	cháng	jiǔ
可	以	長	久
can	by-means-of	long	endure

This is called deep roots and firm foundation

shì	wèi	shēn	gēn	gù	dī
是	謂	深	根	固	柢
this	called	deep	root	firm	foundation

This is the way of long life and lasting vision

cháng	shēng	jiǔ	shì	zhī	dào
長	生	久	視	之	道
long	life	lasting	vision	of	way

Chapter 60

Governing a large country is like cooking small fish.

zhì	dà	guó	ruò	pēng	xiǎo	xiǎn
治	大	國	若	烹	小	鮮
govern	great	country	like	cook	small	fish

When using the Way to oversee the world,

yǐ	dào	lì	tiān	xià
以	道	莅	天	下
by-means-of	way	oversee	heaven	below

Their spirits will not be supernatural.

qí	guǐ	bù	shén
其	鬼	不	神
their	spirits	not	divine

It's not that their spirits are not supernatural.

fēi	qí	guǐ	bù	shén
非	其	鬼	不	神
not	their	spirits	not	divine

Their divinity will not harm people.

qí	shén	bù	shāng	rén
其	神	不	傷	人
their	divine	not	harm	person

It's not that their divinity cannot harm people.

fēi	qí	shén	bù	shāng	rén
非	其	神	不	傷	人
not	their	divine	not	harm	person

The sage also does not harm people.

shèng	rén	yì	bù	shāng	rén
聖	人	亦	不	傷	人
sage	person	also	not	harm	person

When these two do not harm each other,

fú	liǎng	bù	xiāng	shāng
夫	兩	不	相	傷
thus	two	not	mutually	harm

Therefore their virtues merge and return as one.

gù	dé	jiāo	guī	yān
故	德	交	歸	焉
therefore	virtue	exchange	return	therein

Chapter 61

A great state is like the lower reaches of a river.

dà	guó	zhě	xià	liú
大	國	者	下	流
great	state	one-who	lower	flow

It is the meeting point of all under heaven.

tiān	xià	zhī	jiāo
天	下	之	交
heaven	below	of	intersection

It is the feminine principle of all under heaven.

tiān	xià	zhī	pīn
天	下	之	牝
heaven	below	of	female

The female always overcomes the male through stillness.

pīn	cháng	yǐ	jìng	shèng	mù
牝	常	以	靜	勝	牡
female	always	by-means-of	stillness	overcome	male

Through stillness, she takes the lower position.

yǐ	jìng	wéi	xià
以	靜	為	下
by-means-of	stillness	become	lower

Therefore when a great state lowers itself before a small state,

gù	dà	guó	yǐ	xià	xiǎo	guó
故	大	國	以	下	小	國
therefore	great	state	by-means-of	lower	small	state

It will win over the small state.

zé	qǔ	xiǎo	guó
則	取	小	國
then	gain	small	state

When a small state lowers itself before a great state,

xiǎo	guó	yǐ	xià	dà	guó
小	國	以	下	大	國
small	state	by-means-of	lower	great	state

It will be taken by the great state.

zé	qǔ	yú	dà	guó
則	取	於	大	國
then	gain	by	great	state

Therefore, some lower themselves to gain,

gù	huò	xià	yǐ	qǔ
故	或	下	以	取
therefore	some	lower	by-means-of	gain

And some lower themselves and gain.

huò	xià	ér	qǔ
或	下	而	取
some	lower	and	gain

The great state desires nothing more than to gather and nurture people.

dà	guó	bù	guò	yù	jiān	chù	rén
大	國	不	過	欲	兼	畜	人
great	state	not	exceed	desire	unite	nurture	people

The small state desires nothing more than to serve others.

xiǎo	guó	bù	guò	yù	rù	shì	rén
小	國	不	過	欲	入	事	人
small	state	not	exceed	desire	enter	serve	people

Thus both get what they desire.

fú	liǎng	zhě	gè	dé	qí	suǒ	yù
夫	兩	者	各	得	其	所	欲
indeed	both	ones	each	obtain	their	that-which	desire

The greater one should take the lower position.

dà	zhě	yí	wéi	xià
大	者	宜	為	下
great	one	should	become	lower

Chapter 62

The Dao is the mysterious source of all things.

dào	zhé	wàn	wù	zhī	ào
道	者	萬	物	之	奧
way	that-which	ten-thousand	things	of	mystery

It is the treasure of the virtuous person.

shàn	rén	zhī	bǎo
善	人	之	寶
good	person	of	treasure

It is what protects those who are not virtuous.

bù	shàn	rén	zhī	suǒ	bǎo
不	善	人	之	所	保
not	good	person	of	that-which	protect

Beautiful words can be traded in the marketplace.

měi	yán	kě	yǐ	shì
美	言	可	以	市
beautiful	words	can	by-means-of	market

Noble conduct can earn respect from others.

zūn	xíng	kě	yǐ	jiā	rén
尊	行	可	以	加	人
honorable	conduct	can	by-means-of	add-to	person

When people are not good,

rén	zhī	bù	shàn
人	之	不	善
person	of	not	good

How can they be abandoned?

hé	qì	zhī	yǒu
何	棄	之	有
how	abandon	them	have

Therefore, when establishing the Son of Heaven

gù	lì	tiān	zǐ
故	立	天	子
therefore	establish	heaven	son

And installing the Three Ministers,

zhì	sān	gōng
置	三	公
install	three	ministers

Though one might present jade discs and four-horse teams,

suī	yǒu	gǒngbì	yǐ	xiān	sīmǎ
雖	有	拱璧	以	先	駟馬
although	have	jade-disc	by-means-of	advance	four-horses

It is not as good as sitting and offering this Dao.

bù	rú	zuò	jìn	cǐ	dào
不	如	坐	進	此	道
not	like	sit	advance	this	way

Why did the ancients treasure this Dao?

gǔ	zhī	suǒyī	guì	cǐ	dào	zhě	hé
古	之	所以	貴	此	道	者	何
ancient	of	reason-why	value	this	way	one-who	what

Did they not say:

bù	yuē
不	曰
not	say

Through it one can obtain what one seeks

yǐ	qiú	dé
以	求	得
by-means-of	seek	obtain

And the guilty can escape punishment?

yǒu	zuì	yǐ	miǎn	xié
有	罪	以	免	邪
have	guilt	by-means-of	avoid	wrong

Therefore it is valued by all under heaven.

gù	wéi	tiān	xià	guì
故	為	天	下	貴
therefore	become	heaven	under	valuable

Chapter 63

Practice non-action.

wéi	wú	wéi
為	無	為
do	without	doing

Attend to non-affairs.

shì	wú	shì
事	無	事
handle	without	affairs

Taste the tasteless.

wèi	wú	wèi
味	無	味
taste	without	flavor

Consider great and small, many and few.

dà	xiǎo	duō	shǎo
大	小	多	少
great	small	many	few

Repay enmity with virtue.

bào	yuàn	yǐ	dé
報	怨	以	德
repay	enmity	by-means-of	virtue

Plan for difficulty while it is still easy.

tú	nán	yú	qí	yì
圖	難	於	其	易
plan	difficult	at	its	easy

Act on the great while it is still small.

wéi	dà	yú	qí	xì
為	大	於	其	細
act	great	at	its	small

All difficult things in the world must arise from the easy.

tiān-xià	nán	shì	bì	zuò	yú	yì
天下	難	事	必	作	於	易
under-heaven	difficult	affairs	must	arise	from	easy

All great things in the world must arise from the small.

tiān-xià	dà	shì	bì	zuò	yú	xì
天下	大	事	必	作	於	細
under-heaven	great	affairs	must	arise	from	small

Therefore the sage never attempts the great.

shì-yì	shèng-rén	zhōng	bù	wéi	dà
是以	聖人	終	不	為	大
therefore	sage	end	not	do	great

And thus can accomplish the great.

gù	néng	chéng	qí	dà
故	能	成	其	大
therefore	can	accomplish	their	greatness

One who makes promises lightly surely lacks trust.

fú	qīng	nuò	bì	guǎ	xìn
夫	輕	諾	必	寡	信
indeed	light	promise	must	few	trust

Much ease surely brings much difficulty.

duō	yì	bì	duō	nán
多	易	必	多	難
much	easy	must	much	difficult

Therefore the sage considers things difficult.

shì-yì	shèng-rén	yóu	nán	zhī		
是	以	聖	人	猶	難	之
therefore		sage		still	difficult	it

And therefore never encounters difficulty.

gù	zhōng	wú	nán	yī
故	終	無	難	矣
therefore	end	without	difficulty	indeed

Chapter 64

What is at peace is easily maintained.

qí	ān	yì	chí
其	安	易	持
its	peace	easy	maintain

What has not yet shown signs is easily planned for.

qí	wèi	zhào	yì	móu
其	未	兆	易	謀
its	not-yet	show-signs	easy	plan

What is brittle is easily broken.

qí	cuì	yì	pàn
其	脆	易	泮
its	brittle	easy	break

What is minute is easily scattered.

qí	wēi	yì	sàn
其	微	易	散
its	minute	easy	scatter

Act on things before they exist.

wéi	zhī	yú	wèi	yǒu
為	之	於	未	有
act	it	at	not-yet	exist

Manage them before they are chaotic.

zhì	zhī	yú	wèi	luàn
治	之	於	未	亂
manage	it	at	not-yet	chaos

A tree that fills the arms' embrace grows from a tiny sprout.

hé bào	zhī	mù	shēng	yú	háo mò
合抱	之	木	生	於	毫末
arms-embrace	of	tree	grow	from	tiny-sprout

A nine-story tower rises from a pile of earth.

jiǔ	céng	zhī	tái	qǐ	yú	lěi tǔ
九	層	之	臺	起	於	累土
nine	story	of	tower	rise	from	piled-earth

A journey of a thousand li begins beneath one's feet.

qiān	lǐ	zhī	xíng	shǐ	yú	zú xià
千	里	之	行	始	於	足下
thousand	li	of	journey	begin	at	under-feet

Those who act on it will ruin it.

wéi	zhě	bài	zhī
為	者	敗	之
act	one-who	ruin	it

Those who grasp it will lose it.

zhí	zhě	shī	zhī
執	者	失	之
grasp	one-who	lose	it

Therefore the sage:

shì yì	shèng rén
是以	聖人
therefore	sage

Through non-action, he never fails.

wú	wéi	gù	wú	bài
無	為	故	無	敗
without	action	therefore	without	fail

Through not grasping, he never loses.

wú	zhí	gù	wú	shī
無	執	故	無	失
without	grasp	therefore	without	lose

People often fail when their task is nearly complete.

mín	zhī	cóng shì	cháng	yú	jī chéng	ér	bài
民	之	從事	常	於	幾成	而	敗
people	of	undertake	often	at	almost-complete	yet	fail
zhī							
之							
it							

Being as careful at the end as at the beginning,

shèn	zhōng	rú	shǐ
慎	終	如	始
careful	end	like	beginning

Then there will be no failure.

zé	wú	bài	shì
則	無	敗	事
then	no	fail	matter

Therefore the sage:

shì yǐ	shèng rén
是以	聖人
therefore	sage

Desires to be without desire,

yù	bù	yù
欲	不	欲
desire	not	desire

Does not value goods difficult to obtain,

bù	guì	nán	dé	zhī	huò
不	貴	難	得	之	貨
not	value	difficult	obtain	of	goods

Learns what others do not learn,

xué	bù	xué
學	不	學
learn	not	learn

Returns to what others have passed by.

fù	zhòng	rén	zhī	suǒ	guò
復	眾	人	之	所	過
return	many	people	of	that-which	pass-by

Thus he helps all things follow their natural way,

yǐ	fù	wàn wù	zhī	zì rán
以	輔	萬物	之	自然
by-means-of	assist	ten-thousand-things	of	natural-way

Yet dares not take action.

ér	bù	gǎn	wéi
而	不	敢	為
yet	not	dare	act

Chapter 65

The ancient masters who were skilled in the Way

gǔ	zhī	shàn	wéi	dào	zhě
古	之	善	為	道	者
ancient	of	good-at	practice	way	one-who

Did not use it to enlighten the people

fēi	yǐ	míng	mín
非	以	明	民
not	by-means-of	enlighten	people

But rather to keep them simple

jiāng	yǐ	yú	zhī
將	以	愚	之
will	by-means-of	simple	them

People are difficult to govern

mín	zhī	nán	zhì
民	之	難	治
people	of	difficult	govern

Because they have too much knowledge

yǐ	qí	zhī	duō
以	其	知	多
by-means-of	their	knowledge	much

Therefore using knowledge to rule the country

gù	yǐ	zhī	zhì	guó
故	以	知	治	國
therefore	by-means-of	knowledge	govern	country

Is to rob the country

guó	zhī	zéi
國	之	賊
country	of	thief

Not using knowledge to rule the country

bù	yǐ	zhī	zhì	guó
不	以	知	治	國
not	by-means-of	knowledge	govern	country

Is the country's good fortune

guó	zhī	fú
國	之	福
country	of	fortune

Knowing these two principles serves as a model

zhī	cǐ	liǎng	zhě	yì	jī	shì
知	此	兩	者	亦	稽	式
know	these	two	ones	also	examine	pattern

Always knowing this pattern

cháng	zhī	jī	shì
常	知	稽	式
always	know	examine	pattern

This is called mysterious virtue

shì	wèi	xuán	dé
是	謂	玄	德
this	called	mysterious	virtue

Mysterious virtue is deep and far-reaching

xuán	dé	shēn	yī	yuǎn	yī
玄	德	深	矣	遠	矣
mysterious	virtue	deep	indeed	far	indeed

It returns with things to the great harmony

yǔ	wù	fǎn	yī
與	物	反	矣
with	things	return	indeed

Only then is great harmony achieved

		nǎi	zhì	dà	shùn
—	—	乃	至	大	順
		then	reach	great	harmony

Chapter 66

The reason rivers and seas can be kings of hundred valleys

jiāng	hǎi	suǒyī	néng	wéi	bǎi	gǔ	wáng
江	海	所以	能	為	百	谷	王
river	sea	reason-why	can	become	hundred	valleys	king
zhě							
者							
is							

Is because they excel at staying below them.

yǐ	qí	shàn	xià	zhī
以	其	善	下	之
by-means-of	their	excel-at	below	them

Therefore they can be kings of hundred valleys.

gù	néng	wéi	bǎi	gǔ	wáng
故	能	為	百	谷	王
therefore	can	become	hundred	valleys	king

Thus when the sage

shì	yǐ	shèngrén
是	以	聖人
thus	by-means-of	sage

Wishes to be above the people

yù	shàng	mín
欲	上	民
wish	above	people

Must by words place himself below them

bì	yǐ	yán	xià	zhī
必	以	言	下	之
must	by-means-of	words	below	them

Wishes to be ahead of the people

yù	xiān	mín
欲	先	民
wish	ahead	people

Must by body place himself behind them

bì	yǐ	shēn	hòu	zhī
必	以	身	後	之
must	by-means-of	body	behind	them

Thus when the sage

shì	yǐ	shèng	rén
是	以	聖	人
thus	by-means-of	sage	person

Dwells above yet people do not feel burdened

chǔ	shàng	ér	mín	bù	zhòng
處	上	而	民	不	重
dwelt	above	yet	people	not	burden

Stays ahead yet people are not harmed

chǔ	qián	ér	mín	bù	hài
處	前	而	民	不	害
dwelt	front	yet	people	not	harm

Thus the world joyfully pushes them forward without wearying

shìyì	tiānxià	lè	tuī	ér	bù	yàn		
是	以	天	下	樂	推	而	不	厭
therefore		world		joy	push	yet	not	weary

Because they do not contend

yǐ	qí	bù	zhēng
以	其	不	爭
by-means-of	their	not	contend

Therefore none in the world can contend with them

gù	tiānxià	mò	néng	yǔ	zhī	zhēng	
故	天	下	莫	能	與	之	爭
therefore	world	none	can	with	them		contend

Chapter 67

All under heaven say I am great while seeming unlike it.

tiān	xià	jiē	wèi	wǒ	dà
天	下	皆	謂	我	—— 大
heaven	below	all	say	I	great

Appearing unlike greatness.

sì	bù	xiào
似	不	肖
seem	not	resemble

Precisely because of not resembling greatness, one can be truly great.

fú	wéi	bùxiào	gù	néng	dà
夫	唯	不肖	故	能	大
indeed	only	not-resemble	therefore	can	great

Were I to resemble greatness...

ruò	xiào
若	肖
if	resemble

Long indeed would I have remained small.

jiǔ	yī	qí	xì	yě
久	矣	其	細	也
long	already	its	small	indeed

Indeed, I have three treasures.

fú	wǒ	yǒu	sān	bǎo
夫	我	有	三	寶
indeed	I	have	three	treasures

Hold them and protect them.

chí	ér	bǎo	zhī
持	而	保	之
hold	and	protect	them

The first is called compassion.

yī	yuē	cí
一	曰	慈
one	called	compassion

The second is called frugality.

èr	yuē	jiǎn
二	曰	儉
two	called	frugality

The third is called not daring to be ahead of all under heaven.

sān	yuē	bù	gǎn	wéi	tiān	xià	xiān
三	曰	不	敢	為	天	下	先
three	called	not	dare	be	heaven	below	first

Through compassion, one can be courageous.

cí	gù	néng	yǒng
慈	故	能	勇
compassion	therefore	can	brave

Through frugality, one can be generous.

jiǎn	gù	néng	guǎng
儉	故	能	廣
frugality	therefore	can	broad

Not daring to be ahead of all under heaven.

bù	gǎn	wéi	tiān	xià	xiān
不	敢	為	天	下	先
not	dare	be	heaven	below	first

Therefore can become a perfected vessel and leader.

gù	néng	chéng	qì	zhǎng
故	能	成	器	長
therefore	can	become	vessel	leader

Now abandoning compassion for courage.

jīn	shě	cí	qiě	yǒng
今	舍	慈	且	勇
now	abandon	compassion	and	brave

Abandoning frugality for expansion.

shě	jiǎn	qiě	guǎng
舍	儉	且	廣
abandon	frugality	and	broad

Abandoning the rear to go ahead.

shě	hòu	qiě	xiān
舍	後	且	先
abandon	behind	and	first

Death indeed!

sǐ	yī
死	矣
death	indeed

Indeed, with compassion, in battle one is victorious.

fú	cí	yǐ	zhàn	zé	shèng
夫	慈	以	戰	則	勝
indeed	compassion	by-means-of	battle	then	victory

In defense, one is secure.

yǐ	shǒu	zé	gù
以	守	則	固
by-means-of	defend	then	firm

Heaven will save.

tiān	jiāng	jiù	zhī
天	將	救	之
heaven	will	save	it

With compassion protect it.

yǐ	cí	wèi	zhī
以	慈	衛	之
by-means-of	compassion	guard	it

Chapter 68

The best warrior does not display martial prowess.

shàn	wéi	shì	zhě	bù	wǔ
善	為	士	者	不	武
good-at	act-as	warrior	one-who	not	martial

The best fighter never becomes angry.

shàn	zhàn	zhě	bù	nù
善	戰	者	不	怒
good-at	battle	one-who	not	anger

The best conqueror does not engage the enemy.

shàn	shèng	dí	zhě	bù	yǔ
善	勝	敵	者	不	與
good-at	defeat	enemy	one-who	not	engage

The best employer of people places themselves below others.

shàn	yòng	rén	zhě	wéi	zhī	xià
善	用	人	者	為	之	下
good-at	use	people	one-who	act-as	them	below

This is called the virtue of non-contention.

shì	wéi	bù	zhēng	zhī	dé
是	謂	不	爭	之	德
this	called	non	contention	of	virtue

This is called using the strength of others.

shì	wèi	yòng	rén	zhī	lì
是	謂	用	人	之	力
this	called	use	people	of	strength

This is called matching the ancient ultimate principle of heaven.

shì	wèi	pèi	tiān	gǔ	zhī	jí	
是	謂	配	天	古	之	極	也
this	called	match	heaven	ancient	of	ultimate	indeed

Chapter 69

In military affairs, there is a saying:

yòng bīng	yǒu	yán
用兵	有	言
use-military	have	saying

I dare not be the host, but rather be the guest.

wú	bù	gǎn	wéi	zhǔ	ér	wéi	kè
吾	不	敢	為	主	而	為	客
I	not	dare	act-as	host	but	act-as	guest

I dare not advance an inch, but retreat a foot.

bù	gǎn	jìn	cùn	ér	tuì	chǐ
不	敢	進	寸	而	退	尺
not	dare	advance	inch	but	retreat	foot

This is called marching without marching.

shì	wèi	xíng	wú	xíng
是	謂	行	無	行
this	called	march	without	marching

Rolling up sleeves without arms.

ràng	wú	bì
攘	無	臂
roll-up	without	arms

Grasping without weapons.

rēng	wú	dí
扔	無	敵
grasp	without	enemy

Confronting without troops.

zhí	wú	bīng
執	無	兵
hold	without	troops

No disaster is greater than underestimating the enemy.

huò	mò	dà	yú	qīng	dí
禍	莫	大	於	輕	敵
disaster	none	greater	than	treat-lightly	enemy

Underestimating the enemy nearly loses my treasure.

qīng	dí	jī	sàng	wú	bǎo
輕	敵	幾	喪	吾	寶
treat-lightly	enemy	nearly	lose	my	treasure

Therefore when armies oppose each other,

gù	kàng	bīng	xiāng	ruò
故	抗	兵	相	若
therefore	oppose	armies	mutually	like

The sorrowful one will be victorious.

zé	āi	zhě	shèng	yī
則	哀	者	勝	矣
then	sorrowful	one	victory	indeed

Chapter 70

My words are very easy to understand.

wú	yán	shèn	yì	zhī
吾	言	甚	易	知
I	words	very	easy	understand

Very easy to practice.

shèn	yì	xíng
甚	易	行
very	easy	practice

Yet under heaven none can understand them.

ér	tiān-xià	mò	zhī	néng	zhī
而	天下	莫	之	能	知
yet	under-heaven	none	it	can	understand

None can practice them.

mò	zhī	néng	xíng
莫	之	能	行
none	it	can	practice

Words have their source.

yán	yǒu	zōng
言	有	宗
words	have	source

Affairs have their ruler.

shì	yǒu	jūn
事	有	君
affairs	have	ruler

It is only through not understanding.

fú	wéi	wú	zhī
夫	唯	無	知
indeed	only	not	understand

Therefore they do not understand me.

shì-yǐ	bù	wǒ	zhī
是以	不	我	知
therefore	not	me	understand

Those who understand me are few.

zhī	wǒ	zhě	xī
知	我	者	希
understand	me	those-who	rare

Thus I am valued.

zé	wǒ	zhě	guì	yī
則	我	者	貴	矣
then	I	one	precious	indeed

Therefore the sage

shì-yǐ shèng-rén
是以 聖人
therefore sage

Wears coarse cloth while embracing jade within.

pī hè ér huái yù
被 褐 而 懷 玉
wear coarse-cloth yet embrace jade

Chapter 71

To know what one does not know is highest.

zhī	bù	zhī	shàng	yī
知	不	知	尚	矣
know	not	know	highest	indeed

Not knowing what one knows is affliction.

bù	zhī	zhī	bīng	yī
不	知	知	病	矣
not	know	know	illness	indeed

Indeed, it is by recognizing affliction as affliction,

fú	wéi	bīng	bīng
夫	唯	病	病
indeed	only	illness	illness

That one is free from affliction.

shì	yǐ	bù	bīng
是	以	不	病
this	by-means-of	not	illness

The sage is free from affliction.

shèng	rén	bù	bīng
聖	人	不	病
sage	person	not	illness

Because he recognizes affliction as affliction,

yǐ	qí	bìng	bìng
以	其	病	病
by-means-of	his	illness	illness

Therefore he is free from affliction.

shì	yǐ	bù	bìng
是	以	不	病
this	by-means-of	not	illness

Chapter 72

When people do not fear authority,

mín	bù	wèi	wēi
民	不	畏	威
people	not	fear	authority

Then great authority will arrive indeed.

zé	dà	wēi	zhì	yī
則	大	威	至	矣
then	great	authority	arrive	indeed

Do not restrict where they dwell,

wú	xiá	qí	suǒ	jū
無	狎	其	所	居
do-not	restrict	their	place	dwell

Do not weary them in their livelihood.

wú	yàn	qí	suǒ	shēng
無	厭	其	所	生
do-not	weary	their	that-which	live

It is because you do not oppress them,

fú	wéi	bù	yàn
夫	唯	不	厭
indeed	only	not	oppress

Therefore they will not be wearied.

shì	yǐ	bù	yàn
是	以	不	厭
this	by-means-of	not	weary

Therefore the sage

shì	yǐ	shèng	rén
是	以	聖	人
this	by-means-of	sage	person

Knows himself but does not display himself.

zì	zhī	bù	zì	xiàn
自	知	不	自	見
self	know	not	self	display

Loves himself but does not exalt himself.

zì	ài	bù	zì	guì
自	愛	不	自	貴
self	love	not	self	value

Therefore he rejects that and chooses this.

gù	qù	bǐ	qǔ	cǐ
故	去	彼	取	此
therefore	reject	that	choose	this

Chapter 73

To be brave in daring leads to death.

yǒng	yú	gǎn
勇	於	敢
brave	in	dare

Then there is killing.

zé	shā
則	殺
then	kill

To be brave in not daring leads to life.

yǒng	yú	bù	gǎn
勇	於	不	敢
brave	in	not	dare

Then there is life.

zé	huó
則	活
then	live

Of these two, one brings benefit, one brings harm.

cǐ	liǎng	zhě	huò	lì	huò	hài
此	兩	者	或	利	或	害
these	two	ones	perhaps	benefit	perhaps	harm

That which Heaven abhors - who knows the reason?

tiān	zhī	suǒ	wù	shú	zhī	qí	gù
天	之	所	惡	孰	知	其	故
heaven	of	that-which	detest	who	know	its	reason

Thus even the sage finds this difficult.

shì	yǐ	shèng	rén	yóu	nán	zhī
是	以	聖	人	猶	難	之
this	by-means-of	sage	person	still	difficult	it

The Way of Heaven:

tiān	zhī	dào
天	之	道
heaven	of	way

Not contending, yet skillfully prevailing.

bù	zhēng	ér	shàn	shèng
不	爭	而	善	勝
not	contend	yet	good-at	prevail

Not speaking, yet skillfully responding.

bù	yán	ér	shàn	yìng
不	言	而	善	應
not	speak	yet	good-at	respond

Not summoned, yet coming of itself.

bù	zhào	ér	zì	lái
不	召	而	自	來
not	summon	yet	self	come

Unhurried, yet skillfully planning.

chán	rán	ér	shàn	móu
繚	然	而	善	謀
slow	thus	yet	good-at	plan

Heaven's net is vast,

tiān	wǎng	huī	huī
天	網	恢	恢
heaven	net	vast	vast

Loosely meshed, yet nothing slips through.

shū	ér	bù	shī
疏	而	不	失
loose	yet	not	lose

Chapter 74

The people do not fear death.

mín	bù	wèi	sǐ
民	不	畏	死
people	not	fear	death

How then can death be used to frighten them?

nài	hé	yǐ	sǐ	jù	zhī
奈	何	以	死	懼	之
how	what	by-means-of	death	frighten	them

If the people were made to constantly fear death,

ruò	shǐ	mín	cháng	wèi	sǐ
若	使	民	常	畏	死
if	cause	people	always	fear	death

And I could seize and execute those who do strange things,

ér	wéi	qí	zhě	wú	dé	zhí	ér	shā
而	為	奇	者	吾	得	執	而	殺
and	do	strange	ones	I	could	seize	and	kill

之

zhī

them

Who would dare?

shú	gǎn
孰	敢
who	dare

There is always an official executioner.

cháng	yǒu	sī	shā	zhě	—
常	有	司	殺	者	—
always	have	officer	kill	one	

Now, to kill in place of the executioner,

fú	dài	sī	shā	zhě	shā
夫	代	司	殺	者	殺
now	replace	officer	kill	one	kill

This is like cutting in place of the master carpenter.

shì	wèi	dài	dà	jiàng	zhuó
是	謂	代	大	匠	斲
this	called	replace	great	craftsman	cut

One who cuts in place of the master carpenter,

fú	dài	dà	jiàng	zhuó	zhě
夫	代	大	匠	斲	者
now	replace	great	craftsman	cut	one

Rarely escapes injuring their own hands.

xī		bù	shāng	qí	shǒu	yǐ
希	—	不	傷	其	手	矣
rare		not	harm	one's	hand	indeed

Chapter 75

When the people are hungry...

mín zhī jī
民 之 饑
people of hungry

It is because their rulers consume too much in taxes.

yǐ qí shàng shí shuì zhī duō
以 其 上 食 稅 之 多
by-means-of their above eat tax of much

Thus they are hungry.

shì yǐ jī
是 以 饑
this therefore hungry

When the people are difficult to govern...

mín zhī nán zhì
民 之 難 治
people of difficult govern

It is because their rulers interfere too much.

yǐ qí shàng zhī yǒu wéi
以 其 上 之 有 為
by-means-of their above of have do

Thus they are difficult to govern.

shì	yǐ	nán	zhì
是	以	難	治
this	therefore	difficult	govern

When the people take death lightly...

mín	zhī	qīng	sǐ
民	之	輕	死
people	of	light	death

It is because they seek too much life.

yǐ	qí	qiú	shēng	zhī	hòu
以	其	求	生	之	厚
by-means-of	their	seek	life	of	excessive

Thus they take death lightly.

shì	yǐ	qīng	sǐ
是	以	輕	死
this	therefore	light	death

Only the one who does not strive after life...

fú	wéi	wú	yǐ	shēng	wéi	zhě
夫	唯	無	以	生	為	者
indeed	only	without	by-means-of	life	do	one-who

Is wiser than those who value life too dearly.

shì	xián	yú	guì	shēng
是	賢	於	貴	生
this	worthy	than	value	life

Chapter 76

When people are born, they are soft and weak.

rén	zhī	shēng	yě	róu	ruò
人	之	生	也	柔	弱
person	of	live	indeed	soft	weak

At death, they are hard and strong.

qí	sǐ	yě	jiān	qiáng
其	死	也	堅	強
their	die	indeed	hard	strong

When plants and trees are born, they are soft and fragile.

wàn	wù	cǎo	mù	zhī	shēng	yě	róu	cù
萬	物	草	木	之	生	也	柔	脆
ten-thousand	things	grass	tree	of	live	indeed	soft	fragile

At death, they are withered and dry.

qí	sǐ	yě	kū	gāo
其	死	也	枯	槁
their	die	indeed	withered	dried

Thus, that which is hard and strong is a companion of death.

gù	jiān	qiáng	zhě	sǐ	zhī	tú
故	堅	強	者	死	之	徒
therefore	hard	strong	one-who	death	of	companion

That which is soft and weak is a companion of life.

róu	ruò	zhě	shēng	zhī	tú
柔	弱	者	生	之	徒
soft	weak	one-who	life	of	companion

Therefore, when an army is strong, it will not prevail.

shì	yǐ	bīng	qiáng	zé	bù	shèng
是	以	兵	強	則	不	勝
this	by-means-of	weapon	strong	then	not	prevail

When a tree is strong, it will be cut down.

mù	qiáng	zé	bīng
木	強	則	兵
tree	strong	then	weapon

The strong and great dwell below.

qiáng	dà	chù	xià
強	大	處	下
strong	great	dwell	below

The soft and weak dwell above.

róu	ruò	chù	shàng
柔	弱	處	上
soft	weak	dwell	above

Chapter 77

The way of Heaven is like drawing a bow:

tiān	zhī	dào	qí	yóu	zhāng	gōng	yǔ
天	之	道	其	猶	張	弓	與
heaven	of	way	it	like	draw	bow	indeed

What is high, it brings down.

gāo	zhě	yì	zhī
高	者	抑	之
high	that-which	press-down	it

What is low, it raises up.

xià	zhě	jǔ	zhī
下	者	舉	之
low	that-which	lift	it

From those with excess, it takes away.

yǒu	yú	zhě	sǔn	zhī
有	餘	者	損	之
have	excess	that-which	reduce	it

To those lacking, it adds.

bù	zú	zhě	bǔ	zhī
不	足	者	補	之
not	sufficient	that-which	supplement	it

The way of Heaven:

tiān	zhī	dào
天	之	道
heaven	of	way

Reduces excess and supplements insufficiency.

sǔn	yǒu	yú	ér	bǔ	bù	zú
損	有	餘	而	補	不	足
reduce	have	excess	and	supplement	not	sufficient

The way of humans is not thus:

rén	zhī	dào	zé	bù	rán
人	之	道	則	不	然
human	of	way	then	not	so

They take from those who lack to serve those who have excess.

sǔn	bù	zú	yǐ	fèng	yǒu	yú
損	不	足	以	奉	有	餘
reduce	not	sufficient	by-means-of	serve	have	excess

Who can take their excess and offer it to the world?

shú	néng	yǒu	yú	ér	fèng	yú	tiān	xià
孰	能	有	餘	而	奉	於	天	下
who	can	have	excess	and	serve	to	heaven	below

Only one who possesses the Way.

wéi	yǒu	dào	zhě
唯	有	道	者
only	have	way	one

Therefore the sage:

shì	yǐ	shèng	rén
是	以	聖	人
this	therefore	sage	person

Acts but does not rely on it.

wéi	ér	bù	shì
為	而	不	恃
act	yet	not	rely-on

Achieves merit but does not dwell on it.

gōng	chéng	ér	bù	chǔ
功	成	而	不	處
merit	complete	yet	not	dwell

They do not wish to display their wisdom.

qí	bù	yù	xiàn	xián
其	不	欲	見	賢
their	not	desire	show	worthy

Chapter 78

Nothing in the world is softer and weaker than water.

tiān	xià	mò	róuruò	yú	shuǐ
天	下	莫	柔弱	於	水
heaven	below	none	soft-weak	than	water

Yet in attacking the firm and strong.

ér	gōng	jiǎnqiáng	zhě
而	攻	堅強	者
yet	attack	hard-strong	one

Nothing can surpass it.

mò	zhī	néng	shèng
莫	之	能	勝
none	it	can	surpass

Because nothing can take its place.

yǐ	qí	wú	yǐ	yì	zhī
以	其	無	以	易	之
by-means-of	its	nothing	by-means-of	change	it

The weak overcomes the strong.

ruò	zhī	shèng	qiáng
弱	之	勝	強
weak	possessive	overcome	strong

The soft overcomes the hard.

róu	zhī	shèng	gāng
柔	之	勝	剛
soft	possessive	overcome	hard

Everyone in the world knows this.

tiān	xià	mò	bù	zhī
天	下	莫	不	知
heaven	below	none	not	know

Yet none can put it into practice.

mò	néng	xíng
莫	能	行
none	can	practice

Therefore the sage says:

shì	yǐ	shèng	rén	yún
是	以	聖	人	云
this	therefore	sage	person	say

One who accepts the state's filth

shòu	guó	zhī	gòu
受	國	之	垢
receive	state	of	filth

Is called the master of the state altars.

shì	wèi	shèjì	zhī	zhǔ
是	謂	社稷	之	主
this	called	state-altars	of	master

One who bears the state's misfortunes

shòu	guó	zhī	búxiáng
受	國	之	不祥
receive	state	of	misfortune

Is called the king of all under heaven.

shì	wèi	tiān	xià	zhī	wáng
是	謂	天	下	之	王
this	called	heaven	below	of	king

True words seem paradoxical.

zhèng	yán	ruò	fǎn
正	言	若	反
correct	words	like	opposite

Chapter 79

In reconciling great resentment

hé	dà	yuàn
和	大	怨
reconcile	great	resentment

There must remain some resentment.

bì	yǒu	yú	yuàn
必	有	餘	怨
must	have	remaining	resentment

How can this be considered good?

ān	kě	yǐ	wéi	shàn
安	可	以	為	善
how	can	by-means-of	consider	good

Therefore the sage

shì	yǐ	shèng	rén
是	以	聖	人
this	by-means-of	sage	person

Holds the left side of the contract

zhí	zuó	qì
執	左	契
hold	left	contract

And does not demand from others

ér	bù	zé	yú	rén
而	不	責	於	人
yet	not	demand	from	person

Therefore, those with virtue oversee contracts

yǒu	dé	sī	qì	
故	有	德	司	契
therefore	have	virtue	manage	contract

Those without virtue oversee taxation

wú	dé	sī	chè
無	德	司	徹
without	virtue	manage	taxation

The Way of Heaven has no favorites

tiān	dào	wú	qīn
天	道	無	親
heaven	way	without	favorites

It constantly sides with the good person

cháng	yǔ	shàn	rén
常	與	善	人
constant	with	good	person

Chapter 80

A small state with few people:

xiǎo	guó	guǎ	mín
小	國	寡	民
small	state	few	people

Though they have tools for tens and hundreds, they do not use them.

shǐ	yǒu	shí-bǎi	zhī	qì	ér	bù	yòng
使	有	什伯	之	器	而	不	用
let	have	tens-and-hundreds	of	tools	yet	not	use

Let the people regard death seriously and not migrate far.

shǐ	mín	zhòng	sǐ	ér	bù	yuǎn	xí
使	民	重	死	而	不	遠	徙
let	people	heavy	death	yet	not	far	migrate

Although they have boats and carriages, they have nowhere to ride them.

sui	yǒu	zhōu-yú	wú	suǒ	chéng	zhī
雖	有	舟輿	無	所	乘	之
although	have	boats-and-carriages	no	place	ride	them

Although they have armor and weapons, they have nowhere to display them.

sui	yǒu	jiǎ-bīng	wú	suǒ	chén	zhī
雖	有	甲兵	無	所	陳	之
although	have	armor-and-weapons	no	place	display	them

Let the people return to using knotted ropes.

shǐ	mín	fù	jié	shéng	ér	yòng	zhī
使	民	復	結	繩	而	用	之
let	people	return	tie	rope	and	use	it

They find their food sweet.

gān	qí	shí
甘	其	食
sweet	their	food

They find their clothes beautiful.

měi	qí	fú
美	其	服
beautiful	their	clothes

They are peaceful in their dwellings.

ān	qí	jū
安	其	居
peaceful	their	dwelling

They delight in their customs.

lè	qí	sù
樂	其	俗
delight	their	customs

Neighboring states might be within sight of each other.

lín	guó	xiāng	wàng
鄰	國	相	望
neighboring	states	mutually	gaze

The sounds of roosters and dogs can be heard from one to another.

jī	quǎn	zhī	shēng	xiāng	wén
雞	犬	之	聲	相	聞
rooster	dog	of	sound	mutually	hear

The people grow old and die.

mín	zhì	lǎo	sǐ
民	至	老	死
people	until	old	die

Yet they do not visit one another.

bù	xiāng	wǎng	lái
不	相	往	來
not	mutually	go	come

Chapter 81

Truthful words are not beautiful.

xìn	yán	bù	měi
信	言	不	美
truthful	words	not	beautiful

Beautiful words are not truthful.

měi	yán	bù	xìn
美	言	不	信
beautiful	words	not	truthful

The good are not argumentative.

shàn	zhě	bù	biàn
善	者	不	辯
good	one-who	not	argue

The argumentative are not good.

biàn	zhě	bù	shàn
辯	者	不	善
argue	one-who	not	good

The wise are not widely learned.

zhī	zhě	bù	bó
知	者	不	博
wise	one-who	not	broad-learning

The widely learned are not wise.

bó	zhě	bù	zhī
博	者	不	知
broad-learning	one-who	not	wise

The sage does not accumulate.

shèng	rén	bù	jī
聖	人	不	積
sage	person	not	accumulate

Having used it for others, one has even more.

jì	yǐ	wéi	rén	jǐ	yù	yǒu
既	以	為	人	己	愈	有
already	by-means-of	do-for	others	self	more	have

Having given to others, one has even greater abundance.

jì	yǐ	yǔ	rén	jǐ	yù	duō
既	以	與	人	己	愈	多
already	by-means-of	give	others	self	more	abundant

The Way of Heaven benefits and does not harm.

tiān	zhī	dào	lì	ér	bù	hài
天	之	道	利	而	不	害
heaven	of	way	benefit	yet	not	harm

The Way of the sage acts without contention.

shèng	rén	zhī	dào	wéi	ér	bù	zhēng
聖	人	之	道	為	而	不	爭
sage	person	of	way	act	yet	not	contend

